

A person wearing a green jacket is holding a falcon. The background is a blurred city street at night. The text "RISE WITH US." is overlaid in large white letters.

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NEARBY



KKNPP generates 1.30 lakh million units of power

TIRUNELVELI
The Kudankulam Nuclear Power Project (KKNPP) has so far generated 1,30,627 million units of power since its commissioning. » PAGE 6

No outsiders attended T.N. Cabinet meetings

CHENNAI
Tamil Nadu Social Justice Minister Vanni Arasu has denied allegations that 'outsiders' took part in State Cabinet meetings. » PAGE 6

CLASSIFIEDS » PAGES 8, 9 & 10
MAGAZINE » 8 PAGES
DOWNTOWN » 8 PAGES
(TABLOID) (IN SELECT AREAS)

PM takes note of Gen Z anxieties, warns against 'intellectual Naxals'

Prime Minister Modi, addressing the nation on Independence Day, highlights India's economic and security concerns; he announces AI skilling for more than one crore youth, competitive examination coaching, and talent hunt for 2036 Olympics

Nistula Hebbar
NEW DELHI

Addressing the nation from the ramparts of Red Fort on the 80th Independence Day of India, just days after massive youth protests rocked the capital, Prime Minister Narendra Modi stressed a seven-point economic reform plan and an outreach to Gen Z youth, promising AI skilling programmes and free online coaching, in an attempt to tackle post-globalisation anxieties. He also warned the country about the threat of "dimagi Naxals" – intellectual or ideological Naxals – in society, even after the eradication of armed left-wing extremism.

At the first Independence Day that saw *Vande*



Reaching out: PM Narendra Modi meets schoolchildren during the Independence Day celebrations at the Red Fort. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Mataram preceding the National Anthem, the Prime Minister directly addressed challenges facing the youth, from employment worries to the incursion of Artificial Intelligence in everyday life. More than one crore youth will be provided AI skills in a "mission mode" drive over the

coming year, Mr. Modi said. India's digital public infrastructure will be used to provide free online coaching to students wishing to take various competitive exams, and there will be a nationwide sports talent hunt among children between five and 15 years of age ahead of the 2036

CJI expresses confidence in young lawyers

NEW DELHI
Making his Independence Day address at the Supreme Court on Saturday, Chief Justice of India Surya Kant highlighted the "remarkable resilience" of youth and said that the "Bar and Bench remain committed to the growth" of young law graduates. » PAGE 12

BJP seeks Cong's apology in row on National Song

NEW DELHI
The rendition of the full six stanzas of *Vande Mataram* at the Congress's headquarters has triggered a controversy with the BJP seeking an apology from the Opposition party after accusing its leader Sonia Gandhi of trying to stop the song. » PAGE 13

Olympic Games, he added. This acknowledgement of Gen Z anxieties that spilled over into the recent Jantar Mantar protests was, however, spiked by a warning about "intellectual Naxals", who, Mr. Modi said, should be identified and isolated. We have succeeded in eliminating

armed Naxalites from the forests and freeing the country from that grave threat, but these *dimagi* Naxalites are waiting for opportunities," he said.

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MORE REPORTS ON
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People must develop zero tolerance for corruption, says CM



Tough stand: Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay at the Independence Day event held in Chennai on Saturday. M. SRINATH

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

In his first Independence Day speech as Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu on Saturday, C. Joseph Vijay once again drove home the message that the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam's (TVK) mission is to provide a "corruption-free government" and appealed to officials and the people to make the State corruption-free. Delivering the speech af-

ter hoisting the National Flag at the ramparts of Fort St. George, Mr. Vijay thanked the people for breaking away from "caste and religious considerations" and rejecting "money and muscle power." "We are working in mission mode to achieve a corruption-free government. We want our people to develop zero tolerance for corruption," he said.

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Farmers, police clash in Haryana during protest against Independence Day event

The Hindu Bureau
GURUGRAM

Six Haryana Police personnel, including Hansi Superintendent of Police (SP) Vinod Kumar, and a number of protesters were injured on Saturday after the police clashed with members of farmer unions and khap panchayats who were marching towards the venue of an Independence Day programme in Hansi. Both the police and protesters reportedly engaged in stone-pelting during the clashes.

Over a dozen farmer leaders and around 150 unidentified persons have been booked on charges including attempt to murder, rioting, unlawful assembly, subversive activi-



Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini during the Independence Day event in Hisar on Saturday, which the protesters planned to 'disrupt'. PTI

ties, and voluntarily causing hurt to a public servant. Several farmer leaders were taken into preventive detention earlier in the day.

The clashes broke out near Sisai village when a group of farmers, includ-

ing women, attempted to proceed towards the venue where Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini was scheduled to hoist the National Flag to mark Independence Day.

The protesters had earlier announced plans to

disrupt the programme, demanding the arrest of the prime accused in the August 4 murder of a dairy operative, Jeevan Kundu, in Hisar.

The Hansi SP told journalists that a call was issued 10 to 12 days ago to disrupt the programme and alleged that protesters pelted stones at police personnel and attempted to run them over using tractors.

Responding to a viral video purportedly showing him throwing stones as well, Mr. Kumar said that police personnel had also resorted to stone-pelting to disperse the crowd and keep protesters away.

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Five killed amid heavy rainfall in Arunachal

Rahul Karmakar
GUWAHATI

At least five people were killed and several others, Army personnel among them, were reported missing in separate incidents across rain-battered Arunachal Pradesh over the last three days.

Four workers were buried under debris when a landslide occurred at the Keojaring-Byaching road construction site near Necho in Upper Subansiri district on Friday, while a woman was confirmed dead and three others reported missing when a vehicle fell off the road into Lohit river at Sarti in Anjaw district on Thursday.

A flash flood and land-

Several reported missing in the rain-battered State, including troops from an Army camp

slide triggered by heavy rainfall on Friday washed away some structures of an Army camp in Pasu Pani area of Dibang Valley district's Anini.

The Army did not specify how many soldiers were swept away after the landslide, but district officials said at least five were missing since the incident occurred. One of them is a Havildar.

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BCI chief apologises for 'hurting' students

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

Days after the Bar Council of India (BCI) tried to prevent graduates from the NALSAR University of Law from enrolling with State Bar Councils before a backlash forced it to recant, the council's chairperson, Manan Kumar Mishra, on Saturday apologised to law students for any hurt caused by his words or communications.

In a three-page letter issued on Independence Day, Mr. Mishra – who is also a senior advocate and Bharatiya Janata Party MP – said he regretted any of his statements or directives that may have hurt students and apologised for them.

"If anything connected with the present controversy, any of my words, or letter, has hurt the feelings of our law students, I sincerely regret and apologise for the same... An expression of regret is not a matter of prestige or ego. It is simply an acknowledgment that the feelings and concerns of our students matter," he said in his letter without naming any particular institution.



CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 12

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TAMIL NADU



Driven by purpose: The School Education and Higher Education Departments will strengthen initiatives such as Anti-Drug Clubs and Student Police Cadets on school and college campuses. The photo shows an anti-drug run in Dindigul in June this year. G. KARTHIKEYAN

Retrofitting Tamil Nadu to strike at drug menace

Governments across the world have struggled to curb the drug menace, driven by cartels. The situation is no different in Tamil Nadu. With the State going through the same classic signs of easy availability of drugs through a wide ground-level network and addiction beginning early among the youth,

S. Vijay Kumar looks at what this government's Anti Narcotics Task Force will do differently as the State takes yet another stab at stamping out drugs

The Tamil Nadu Police have launched a multi-pronged strategy to eradicate substance abuse in the State. The launch of a new force, Anti Narcotics Task Force (ANTF), does not seem to be just another initiative in rhetoric but a concerted effort to end the prevalence of drugs, especially ganja, by taking on drug syndicates, smugglers, and others involved in the high-stakes illegal business.

Three months after the Tamilaga Vettir Kazhagam (TVK) assumed power, it has taken the first big step towards fulfilling Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay's election promise that he would end the drug culture in the State.

Since May 10 this year, 5,082 drug-related cases have been registered in the State and 7,214 suspects have been arrested on the charges of trafficking, possession, and distribution of drugs. More than 7,000 kg of ganja, 112 kg of other drugs, and 3.4 lakh tablets (prescribed drugs obtained without authorisation) were seized.

The special force has been formed in the wake of reports of youth, including college students, getting addicted to ganja and drugs such as methamphetamine or meth, a highly addictive synthetic stimulant, freely available in rave parties. The link between crime and drug addiction is also proven. It is in this context that the government constituted the ANTF, involving multiple stakeholders and law-enforcement agencies.

Though attempts were made in the past to dismantle inter-State drug syndicates and neutralise their supply chain and manpower, the unlawful activity continued to thrive with the suspects adopting newer means of transport and distribution. Even as the State police managed to curtail ganja cultivation in the tri-junction forest area of Tamil Nadu, Kerala, and Karnataka, the flow of the drug continues from Andhra Pradesh and Odisha.

After intensive search operations on train and road routes along inter-State borders, smugglers have stopped moving ganja in large quantities. Now, they engage small-time peddlers to smuggle less than 4 kg to 5 kg per consignment, mostly by train.

Flowing from neighbouring States

While the Narcotics Intelligence Bureau-Criminal Investigation Department (NIB-CID) and the local police have been working in coordination with Central agencies, such as the Narcotics Control Bureau, to contain the prevalence of drugs, the efforts did not yield the desired result. The police suspect that the inflow of ganja or marijuana or cannabis continues from neighbouring States, Andhra Pradesh in particular. Besides local consumption, ganja and other synthetic drugs are smuggled to Sri Lanka with the help of illegal boat operators for further transshipment to South-East Asian countries.

The high-capacity ANTF is a dedicated force. It was born out of a major overhaul of the State's strategy to combat drug trafficking and substance abuse aimed at achieving a 'Drug-Free Tamil Nadu'. The new architecture, sanctioned through a Government Order issued on August 8 this year, seeks to replace the existing enforcement framework with a dedicated, technology-driven, and



Instead of limiting enforcement to the seizure of drugs and arrest of individuals involved in street-level distribution, the ANTF will identify the financial networks supporting organised trafficking

MAHESH KUMAR AGGARWAL, Director-General of Police and Head of the Police Force

intelligence-led system. The initiative combines specialised policing with financial investigations, cyber-surveillance, treatment and rehabilitation of drug addicts, youth engagement, and community participation.

It seeks to significantly expand the State's dedicated anti-narcotics field force by strengthening it with technology. As many as 65 specialised ANTF police stations have been sanctioned; they will cover 37 police districts and eight city police commissionerates. Each of these stations will have one Inspector of Police, four Sub-Inspectors, and 20 police personnel. Together, they will provide 1,625 dedicated personnel for field-level narcotics enforcement across Tamil Nadu.

Not meant for routine policing

A key feature of the new arrangement is that ANTF personnel would not be deployed for routine policing to make sure that the force remains an exclusive deployment agency tasked to maintain sustained surveillance, intelligence-gathering, and investigation of organised drug trafficking networks.

Before the creation of the dedicated ANTF, narcotics enforcement was largely handled by 15 NIB-CID units that functioned under the Enforcement Bureau-CID. While these units played an important role in preventing and detecting narcotics offences, the government realised that the relatively limited manpower and infrastructure available with the 15 NIB-CID units had made it difficult to maintain continuous State-wide surveillance and penetrate sophisticated trafficking networks.

What was needed was a sufficiently strong centralised headquarters with specialised capabilities for State-wide intelligence analysis, cyber-analytics, darknet monitoring, and financial investigation. But none of this was present; the NIB-CID largely relied on local police for intensive combing operations. Further, personnel attached to the local police stations were required

to deal with law-and-order duties, regular crime investigation, and other responsibilities. This often limited the sustained attention that could be devoted to organised narcotics networks. However, the ANTF intends to overcome these hurdles and address these gaps through a centralised command structure and specialised field units.

The ANTF headquarters will be headed by an Additional Director-General of Police and an Inspector-General of Police, assisted by two Superintendents of Police (SP-I for Operations and SP-II for Intelligence and Administration). The headquarters will have 10 specialised wings to integrate intelligence, investigation, technology, operations, legal support, and administration.

Among the key components is a dedicated cyber lab equipped to undertake digital forensics, mobile-data extraction, darknet monitoring, open-source intelligence, and cryptocurrency and blockchain analysis.

A centralised crime records bureau will profile drug offenders, track repeat offenders, map trafficking routes, and identify drug hotspots. A special operations and investigation unit will focus on high-value cases, synthetic drug laboratories, international connections, and complex darknet distribution networks. Field intelligence units will collect information on cultivation sources, inter-State transit corridors, and maritime and coastal smuggling routes.

Legal team to help in searches

The ANTF will also have a dedicated legal unit to provide guidance on search and seizure procedures, investigation, filing of chargesheets, and trial proceedings. A 24x7 control room and helpline will provide real-time operational coordination. The police have solicited information from members of the public on drug-related offenders through the designated toll-free number 10581, while a WhatsApp chatbot facility will be available on 9498410581.

"One of the most significant changes in the State's anti-narcotics strategy will be a greater emphasis on financial investigation. Instead of limiting enforcement to the seizure of drugs and arrest of individuals involved in street-level distribution, the ANTF will identify the financial networks supporting organised trafficking," says Director-General of Police and Head of the Police Force Mahesh Kumar Aggarwal.

Investigators would trace illicit financial flows, identify key players and alleged kingpins, and pursue the freezing and attachment of movable and immovable properties belonging to traffickers and their accomplices under applicable legal provisions. "The objective is to weaken the financial foundations of organised drug syndicates and make trafficking increasingly difficult and unprofitable," Dr. Aggarwal said.

Realising that policing and seizures alone cannot eliminate substance abuse, the government has roped in other departments. The Health and Family Welfare Department will establish protocols for referring first-time and small-quantity drug users for medical treatment, counselling, and rehabilitation. The government also plans to strengthen de-addiction centres, relapse tracking, case-management systems, and drug-testing facilities at district hospitals. Periodic district-le-

vel surveys have been envisaged to assess drug-use patterns and demographics for more effective healthcare interventions.

The School Education and Higher Education Departments will integrate awareness of substance abuse into educational programmes and strengthen Anti-Drug Clubs and Student Police Cadets on school and college campuses. Student volunteers from the NSS and the NCC would be mobilised as 'Anti-Drug Warriors'. Sports competitions would be conducted regularly across the State to encourage young people to participate in constructive activities and discourage drug abuse.

When the Chief Minister administered a pledge against drug abuse in Chennai recently, about 2,000 students took part. More than one crore people joined the event online by logging into the Drug Free Tamil Nadu application. The government has also involved the Rural Development and Municipal Administration Departments to help create village- and ward-level anti-drug committees to strengthen community vigilance. Local bodies that have achieved 'Drug-Free Village' or 'Drug-Free Ward' status will receive State-level recognition and incentives.

The Information and Public Relations Department, the publicity arm of the government, will coordinate sustained public awareness campaigns, social media outreach, and community engagement programmes. The aim is not only to increase awareness of the dangers of drugs but also to encourage public reporting and reduce the stigma associated with seeking treatment.

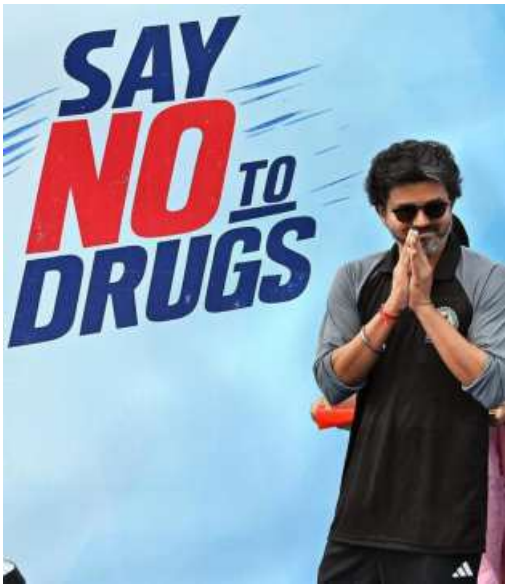
The new framework also provides for a structured system of monitoring and accountability. At the district level, weekly reviews would be chaired by the Collector, along with the District Superintendent of Police or the City Police Commissioner and the local body administrative heads. At the State level, fortnightly reviews would be chaired by the ADGP (ANTF) to assess field operations and tactical progress.

Apex review every month

An apex review will be held every month under the chairmanship of the Chief Secretary. It will focus on coordination among departments, implementation of policy measures, and the overall impact of the anti-narcotics programme. The Chief Minister will be apprised of the outcome of filed operations, seizures, and overall progress and impact of the ANTF on a fortnightly basis, according to police sources.

The government expects the ANTF to mark a shift from conventional drug seizures towards dismantling entire trafficking networks. By combining dedicated manpower with cyber-capabilities, intelligence-gathering, financial investigation, and inter-departmental action, Tamil Nadu aims to tackle both the supply of narcotics and the demand for drugs.

The broader objective is to neutralise organised trafficking networks, protect children and young people, improve access to treatment and rehabilitation, and strengthen community participation in preventing substance abuse — ultimately paving the way for a safer and healthier 'Drug-Free Tamil Nadu'.



Going all out: Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay has taken significant steps to stamp out drugs in line with his election promise. In June, he administered a pledge against drug abuse in Chennai. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

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INBRIEF



Rotary Club of Madras East launches Project DARE

On the occasion of Independence Day, the Rotary Club of Madras East (RCME) has launched Project DARE - Dignity and Rapid Emergency Response, an initiative aimed at providing emergency transportation and support to economically disadvantaged and vulnerable individuals across the city. As part of the initiative, RCME donated an ambulance to The Uravugal Trust, sponsored by PP Rtn. K. Surendra Kumar and PP Rtn. S. Prabhu. The ambulance donated under Project DARE will strengthen the Trust's ability to respond to a range of humanitarian and medical transportation needs, according to a release.

Man arrested for stabbing 18-year-old boy to death

The police arrested Kamesh, 21, for allegedly stabbing Ranjan, 18, to death following a quarrel near Sanaputhur village in Gummidipoondi on Thursday night. The police said that Ranjan was consuming liquor near an agricultural field around 9 p.m. when he got into an argument with Kamesh. The quarrel reportedly began after Ranjan uttered abusive words about Kamesh's wife. Angered by this, Kamesh allegedly attacked Ranjan with a knife and fled the scene, leaving him critically injured. On Friday morning, a watchman at a nearby mango grove found Ranjan lying dead and informed his father. The Padhirivedu police sent the body for post-mortem. The police registered a murder case and arrested Kamesh.

CMRL begins tunnelling work from Perambur Barracks Road to Pattalam for Phase 2 project

Metro Rail officials expect the first phase of the work to be completed in six months; Perambur Barracks Road, Pattalam are part of Corridor 3 connecting northern and southern parts of the city

TRACK TALES

Sunitha Sekar
CHENNAI

Chennai Metro Rail Limited (CMRL) has begun tunnelling work to connect Perambur Barracks Road and Pattalam through an underground network as part of the 118.9 km Phase II project.

The network is expected to improve mobility for thousands of people commuting to these two areas, which are home to many small businesses, commercial establishments, and residential buildings.

Perambur Barracks Road and Pattalam are part of Corridor 3 connecting Madhavaram and Siruseri SIPCOT.

Easing commute

Commuting to localities like Moolaikadai and Sembiyam in north Chennai, and to Thirumayilai, Adyar, Taramani, Thorai-pakkam, Sholinganallur, and SIPCOT in south Chennai, is set to become seamless when train operations



Task ahead: Officials are expecting the tunnel boring machine to work through clayey soil and weathered rock in the Perambur Barracks Road-Pattalam stretch. FILE PHOTO

start on this corridor.

While the station on Perambur Barracks Road is situated near the mosque, the Pattalam station is being built near the Mahalakshmi Theatre on Strahans Road.

Initial progress

According to officials of the CMRL, the first tunnel boring machine (TBM), which began operations

recently, has bored through a distance of nearly 600 metres. "This (underground stretch) is also built as a stacked tunnel where one line is above the other. We had to chalk out this plan due to a lack of sufficient space at Pattalam. We may touch a maximum depth of about 30 metres in this stretch," an official said.

Officials are expecting

the TBMs to bore through clayey soil and weathered rock in this stretch.

The TBM, which is boring under Perambur Barracks Road, will have to pass through residential and commercial areas before taking a left to enter Strahans Road and arrive at Pattalam. "We estimate that the first tunnelling drive will be finished in six months," the official said.

12 juveniles detained over Class 12 student's murder in Tiruvottiyur

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The police have apprehended 12 juveniles in connection with the death of an 18-year-old school student, who was allegedly assaulted by a group of students in Tiruvottiyur.

On Friday evening, the police received information that an 18-year-old was lying unconscious on a vacant plot behind the Ajax Bus Stand, near a government school.

They rushed to the spot and took the boy to Government Stanley Hospital, where he was declared brought dead.

The police identified the deceased as Dhanush, 18, son of Venkatesh, a resident of Vasanth Nagar, Tiruvottiyur. He was studying Class 12 at the Jaigopal Garodia Government Higher Secondary School. Upon receipt of information, Deputy Commissioner of Police, Washermenpet, V. Bakaran, visited the spot and conducted a preliminary inquiry.

Verbal altercation

According to the police, Dhanush and a friend, both Class 12 students of the school, were talking to a female classmate on the school campus on Thursday. At the time, a 17-year-old Class 11 student of the

same school who was passing by allegedly had a verbal altercation with him. On learning about the incident, the school headmaster summoned both students and reprimanded them. Angered by the verbal altercation, the Class 11 student informed his friends when he met them at the vacant ground behind the Ajax Bus Stand on Friday evening. When Dhanush passed by, the group allegedly called him over, picked a quarrel and assaulted him.

Dhanush collapsed and became unconscious following the assault.

Complaint filed

Based on a complaint filed by Dhanush's mother, Lakshmi, 45, the Tiruvottiyur police registered a case and detained 12 juveniles, aged between 16 and 17, who are students of the same school, and questioned them in connection with the assault.

The police said the juveniles will be produced before the Juvenile Justice Board after the inquiry.

Meanwhile, relatives of Dhanush staged a protest on Friday night near the Tiruvottiyur police station. They alleged that around 30 students were involved in the assault and demanded the arrest of all those involved.

Rural Development Dept. engineers complain about lack of promotions

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Rural Development and Panchayat Raj (RD&PR) Department, despite having been allocated ₹39,609 crore in the recent Budget of the State government, has fewer engineers compared to other engineering departments with lower budgetary outlay, according to the Tamil Nadu Rural Development Engineers Association.

Compared to the RD&PR Department,

Rural Development Engineers Association alleges failure to create sufficient posts in the department

where there are two Chief Engineers (CEs) and three Superintending Engineers (SEs), the Water Resources Department, with an allocation of ₹9,264 crore, has 15 CEs and 39 SEs while the Highways and Minor Ports Department (₹21,524 crore) has 10 CEs and 35

SEs, the association contended. The body, which recently submitted a representation to the authorities concerned about the lack of opportunities for promotion of engineers in the department, has called for the establishment of district-level quality control laboratories in the department on the lines of those in the Highways and Minor Ports Department.

This has become a necessity in view of over 100 civil works and road projects taking place across

panchayat unions in the State. The association has complained that due to the failure to create sufficient posts in the department, Assistant Engineers (AEs), numbering around 450, "have been forced to work in the same position for over 15 years without any promotion."

The association has called for the creation of 200 posts for AEs; 100 Assistant Executive Engineers; 50 Executive Engineers; 15 SEs; and five CEs in the RD&PR Department.

Domestic worker among three held for murdering elderly woman in T. Nagar

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Three persons, including a domestic worker, have been arrested in connection with the murder of an 80-year-old woman who was living alone in an apartment on T. Nagar's Kuppusamy Street.

The deceased was identified as Radha.

The police said that Vijay Adhiraj, who lives in the apartment above Radha's house, contacted her son, Ramji Yadav, on Fri-

day morning and informed him that his mother's house was locked and that there was no response despite ringing the doorbell and calling her over the mobile phone.

Ramji went to his mother's house and found her dead with injuries and bleeding from her nose. He also noticed that her gold chain, bangle, and ring, diamond earrings, silver articles, and cash were missing. Based on his complaint, the Pondy Bazaar police found that a wo-

man, identified as Menaka alias Ammu, 36, of MMDA Colony, Arumbakkam, was working at Radha's house as domestic help for the past five months. During questioning, Menaka allegedly confessed that she planned to steal Radha's jewellery with two male acquaintances, Mouli alias Chandramouli and Manikandan.

The police said the three went to Radha's house on Thursday evening, strangled her to death and escaped with the gold jewel-

lery she was wearing and other valuables. The police subsequently arrested Mouli, 26, and Manikandan, 24, both from Teynampet. They also recovered around eight sovereigns of gold jewellery, including a gold chain, bangle and ring, a pair of diamond earrings, silver articles, ₹2,000 in cash and the two-wheeler allegedly used in the crime.

The three accused were remanded in judicial custody.

Timings
CHENNAI
SUNDAY, AUG. 16
☀️ RISE 05:57 SET 18:30
🌙 RISE 08:59 SET 21:06
MONDAY, AUG. 17
☀️ RISE 05:57 SET 18:29
🌙 RISE 09:49 SET 21:45
TUESDAY, AUG. 18
☀️ RISE 05:57 SET 18:29
🌙 RISE 10:39 SET 22:25

Chennai Weather	max	min
Tiruvallur	38	26
Chennai Airport	38	28
Chennai City	38	27

Chennai Airport Today
36°C The weather will be very warm and uneasy. Night will be comfortable. Chances of light rain and thundershower.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
36°C Morning will be comfortable. Day will be very warm. Mostly dry weather to occur at few places. Night also will be comfortable.

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H1N1 influenza cases surface earlier than usual

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

H1N1 influenza cases have been reported at a number of hospitals across the city in recent weeks.

Suresh Kumar, senior consultant, Infectious Diseases, Apollo Hospitals, said they have been seeing H1N1 cases over the past one-and-a-half months, with at least three to four patients presenting to the outpatient department every day and a few requiring hospital admission.

"H1N1 influenza has surfaced even before winter. We usually see cases in September and October but this time, they have surfaced a little earlier," he said, adding that there have been more cases of influenza A virus.

"Some patients have had severe presentations, including severe body ache, headache, back pain and extreme fatigue. These severe presentations have been seen across all age groups. In fact, nasal symptoms such as runny nose and sore throat have been minimal in some, while some have also reported loose stools," Dr.



A government doctor said they are seeing mixed flu-like illness but are unable to confirm H1N1 due to lack of testing. GETTY IMAGES

Suresh Kumar said. He noted that the recommended vaccine for this season is expected to hit the market by the end of the month. "It is important to get vaccinated against H1N1. A few patients have required intensive care, prone ventilation and oxygen support," he added.

Madhumitha R., senior consultant, Infectious Diseases and Infection Control, MGM Healthcare, said that while H1N1 cases have appeared a little earlier this year, the infection is endemic and can be seen at different times of the year. There are short-term rises in cases often fol-

lowed by a decline in numbers. For instance, there was a spike in cases during summer. "But yes, we have been seeing quite a lot of H1N1 influenza cases, specifically influenza A, over the last few weeks. People are presenting with symptoms such as fever, cold, cough and sore throat," Dr. Madhumitha said.

"Influenza vaccines are available throughout the year, with vaccine formulations updated periodically to match the circulating strains and the requirements of the Northern and Southern Hemisphere influenza seasons. Vaccination helps reduce the risk

of severe influenza, and highly vulnerable groups, including older adults, pregnant women and people with underlying medical conditions, should be vaccinated yearly," she said.

The rise in influenza cases has also been observed among children. Janani Sankar, medical director, Kanchi Kamakoti CHILDS Trust Hospital, said they are seeing more cases of influenza A over the last two weeks and recommend following standard preventive measures, including practising cough etiquette, maintaining hand hygiene and getting vaccination against influenza.

Lack of testing

A government doctor said they are seeing mixed flu-like illness but are unable to confirm H1N1 influenza due to lack of testing.

"Patients are presenting with symptoms of fever with headache. Some of them develop gastric symptoms and diarrhoea. Patients improve with symptomatic treatment and antibiotics. In a few patients, the sickness wor-

sens and they require IV injections. Many of them develop leucopenia and thrombocytopenia but they resolve in a few days," he said.

Noting that respiratory symptoms are few this season, he added that they start patients on Oseltamivir if there are any moderate respiratory symptoms. S. Chandrasekar, Professor and Head, Department of Medicine and Critical Care Services, Government Stanley Medical College Hospital, said there have been cases of H1N1 influenza two to three weeks ago, but they were mild in nature. Patients presented with cough, fever, headache and body ache. The symptoms generally lasted three to five days before improving. However, some persons continued to experience exhaustion, while vulnerable groups, including the elderly, reported prolonged illness.

"We expect a surge in cases in the coming months due to the monsoon. Vaccination is the best way to prevent infection, and August and September are the right time to get vaccinated," he said.

‘MTC is intertwined with the everyday lives of Chennaiites’

In Chennai, every journey of the residents is intertwined with the Metropolitan Transport Corporation (MTC), from the first ride of the day to the last ride home.

The MTC originated as the Pallavan Transport Corporation during the time when public bus services were taking shape as an organised transport network.

The MTC has carried the people of the city through a remarkable transformation.

As the city expanded, the bus network also expanded, connecting neighbourhoods, schools, colleges, workplaces, markets, hospitals, and homes, with every bus stop bearing stories to tell.

For generations of Chennai residents, the MTC bus has been more than a means of

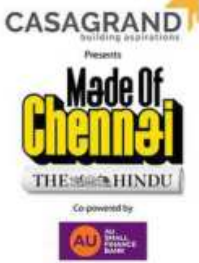


D. Mohan, MD of Metropolitan Transport Corporation.

transport – it has been a part of their everyday lives carrying cherished memories.

This extensive network is not merely a transport system, it is a network of connections that binds Chennai together.

(As told to R. Srikanth)



Sparrow awareness initiative to be held in 50 govt. schools

Students will learn about sparrows' habitat and the challenges they face in urban environments in the workshops to be held by Koodugal Trust in 10 districts, including Chennai and Coimbatore

K. Lakshmi
CHENNAI

With the population of sparrows dwindling and their survival facing challenges due to loss of nesting spaces in urbanised localities, a conservation initiative aims at re-connecting children with the little birds through workshops in government schools across the State.

Koodugal Trust, a voluntary organisation working towards sparrow conservation, is set to conduct environment awareness and nest-box-making workshops in 50 government schools across 10 districts from September.

The initiative, undertaken in partnership with the School Education Department, seeks to sensitise children about the significance of sparrow conservation and encourage them to create safe nesting spaces



Preserving nature: A key component of the programme will be the hands-on nest-box-making sessions. FILE PHOTO

for the birds. As part of the workshops, students will learn about sparrows' habitat and challenges they face in urban environments. A key component of the programme would be the hands-on nest-box-making sessions. By involving students in making nest boxes, the trust plans to turn conservation awareness into an activity that can be taken back to their communities.

Though the trust has reached out to children in about 80 private schools across the State in the past five years, it has obtained approval to conduct the workshops for the first time in government schools. The workshops will be held in districts such as Erode, Coimbatore, Ranipet, Chennai, and Krishnagiri.

“Conserving these tiny birds is important as they

help maintain the natural balance of ecosystem. We have distributed about 15,000 nest boxes in various parts of the State in the past five years,” said D. Ganeshan, convener, Koodugal Trust.

A local estimate by the organisation has found that the house sparrow population has increased by 25% in north Chennai in the past five years and the birds are spotted in other areas such as Velachery, Perumbakkam, and Tambaram, thanks to sustained nest-box-seeding activities.

Students would also be encouraged to participate in a sparrow census. The trust is also planning to launch a mobile application next month that would enable users to record bird calls and images, identify birds, and build record of bird sightings. The application would help collate data on sparrow population, said Mr. Ganeshan.



12 students from T.N. to participate in skills competition in China

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A total of 12 participants, part of a contingent of 70 from Tamil Nadu, have been selected to represent India at the WorldSkills Competition to be held next month in Shanghai, China.

Under the Tamil Nadu Skill Development Corporation (TNSDC), the students are selected through State-level competitions and are trained in their respective skills once selected after the regional rounds.

V.S. Arjun, 20, from Chennai has been selected to represent India under the mobile app development category. “My college encouraged me to register for the skills competition organised by the State government. Once I was selected, the corporation gave me extra training

through various companies in India to hone my skills,” he said.

Along with Arjun, Suresh Kumar G.M., Ragul K.B., Rohit, Mohamed Mafaz P.R., Aswin S., Mohammed Salam Z., Mohanraj, Surendiran, Joy Das, Thanushree, and Gokula Kannan will also participate under various categories including intelligent security technology, cooking, plumbing and heating, and dental prosthetics.

According to a TNSDC official, training for the participants begins as soon as they enter the third round in State-level competitions. “They undergo at least a month-long training to enhance their skills with experts in their domain to prepare them for the competitions. Through these initiatives, we also widen their placement opportunities,” he said.

₹24 lakh goes missing from ATM cash-loading vehicle in the city

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The police have launched an investigation after ₹24 lakh went missing from a cash-loading van carrying money for HDFC Bank ATMs.

Police sources said Cash Secure System (CSS), a company contracted to replenish HDFC Bank ATMs, dispatched a van from the bank's Velachery branch on Friday night carrying ₹4.69 crore packed in 105

The police suspect the missing boxes slipped out of the vehicle onto the road

cash boxes. The cash-loading team replenished 14 ATMs before reaching the 15th ATM on Paper Mills Road. While preparing to load cash into the machine, the employees found that three cash boxes were missing.

The team retraced the

route taken by the van and found two empty cash boxes on the Murasoli Maran Bridge in Perambur.

The police suspect that the boxes, which had ₹24 lakh, fell from the vehicle onto the road. The cash was thrown across the road and could have been taken away by other road users, according to the police.

Following a complaint, the ICF police registered a case and have begun an investigation.

Two youth run over by car while making reels on National Highway

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Two youth were killed when they were allegedly hit by a speeding car on Friday while shooting reels on the middle of the Tha-

chur-Chittoor Greenfield National Highway.

The deceased were identified as E. Jayakumar, 19, and his friend S. Lokesh, 17, both residents of Elayamman Kovil Street in Karlampakkam village

near Pallipattu. The police said that the car coming from Bengaluru towards Chennai hit the youth, killing them on the spot.

Pallipattu police are conducting a detailed investigation.

FSSAI makes U-turn, revokes order against Enrica products

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

On Thursday, the Tamil Nadu State Marketing Corporation (Tasmac) issued a notice across its network of shops, directing them to stop the sale of 11 liquor variants manufactured by Enrica Enterprises Pvt. Ltd following an FSSAI inspection that flagged the presence of natural identical and artificial flavouring substances in the products.

However, the very next day, on Friday, a notice issued by R. Gajalakshmi, Commissioner of Prohibition and Excise, stated that the earlier order had been revoked.

A senior official from the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) said the company had appealed against the prohibition order and assured the authorities that it would comply with the rules. Following this, the prohibition was revoked, and an improvement notice was issued to the company. “We have given them 30 days’ notice. If they fail to comply, we can take further action,” the official said.

The FSSAI, in a letter dated August 11, said that artificial flavouring substance was found and ordered that sales had to be stopped immediately. The variants include VSOP Exshaw Gold Brandy, Louis Vernant XO Blended Premium Brandy, McDowell's VSOP Brandy, No.1 McDowell's Fine Brandy, Mensclub Deluxe Brandy, Honey Bee Fine Brandy, Enrica VSOP Select Brandy, Enrica Platinum Reserve XO Brandy, Enrica Premium French Brandy, Veeran Special Brandy, Enrica Old Indie Classic Dark Rum.

CINEMA ♦ ARTS ♦ EVENTS

MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

AAA / ABBAS / ROSHINI
BENGAL ASSOCIATION A/C
CRAZY MOHAN'S GENE FAME
KATHAKALI NARAKASURA VADHAM
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KNT's "VEERA" A Cinematic
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Road, T.Nagar. Tel:- 044-
28543045. All are welcome!

AAA / CRAZY CREATIONS
VANIMAHAL A/C
TODAY 7.00 pm
CRAZY MOHAN'S
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KRISHNA
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Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan,
East Madas Street, Mylapore, Chennai-4
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between 17- 21 August 2026
17th August: 6.00 pm: Inauguration,
6.30 pm: "Kathakali-Narakasura
Vadham by Natyakala-School of
Dance, 6.30 pm: 18th August :
"Kerala Musical Ensemble" by
Sudeep Palanad & Team, 6.30 pm:
20th August : "Malayalam Short
Plays" by Chennai Nataka Vedhi,
Makthoob Theatre & Mythri
Kalavedi, 6.30 pm: 21st August :
"Avani"- A Cultural Odyssey by
Yogashema Sabha, All are Welcome.

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TODAY 6.15 pm: KRUTHI VIT-
TAL-Vocal by VVS Murari, Sai
Giridhar, Sunil Kumar at Youth
Hostel, 2nd Avenue, Indira
Nagar, Adyar All are welcome
Powered by Super Auto Forge.
Tuesday, 18th August: 6.25 pm:
Annual Day jointly with Sri
Krishna Sweets, Hon'ble Shri-
R.KUMAR Minister for IT, AI &
Digital Services, Govt of Tamil
Nadu, Presides and confers the
DISTINGUISHED CITIZEN OF
THE YEAR AWARD-2026 to Shri
B. SANTHANAM, Former Chair-
man & CEO, Saint Gobain. Fol-
lowed by SPOORTHI RAO
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TEKTON delivers a combination of confidence, stability and sculpted performance. Customers can choose from Turbo T160, Turbo T280 and Turbo T280 DCT power train options featuring 100% turbocharged engines. The Turbo T160 produces 163 Nm of torque, while the Turbo T280 delivers 280 Nm. This C-SUV features a 25.65 cm (10.1-inch) Tek-Link HD infotainment system with Google built-in and a 26.03 cm (10.25-inch) HD digital cockpit. A dual-screen layout seamlessly integrates information, entertainment and vehicle functions through intuitive digital controls. The TEKTON has been engineered to deliver a confident and capable driving experience across all road conditions. Its Smart Powered Tailgate offers one-touch access to the cargo area, making it easier to load and unload heavy items.*Terms and conditions apply.

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1. In 1957, the Madras Dramatic Society and the British Council staged which Shakespeare play at the Museum Theatre, in what is believed to be the first production featuring Indian and English actors together on the same stage?

2. Which future music director made his debut as a child singer with the train-themed song "Chikku Bukku Chikku Bukku Raile" from Gentleman?

3. Founded in 1970 by Cho Ramaswamy, which satirical Tamil magazine became known for its sharp political cartoons and commentary?

Scan the QR or visit
newsthlive/MOC2026PA
to take the quiz. Top 3 winners*
every day win gift vouchers.

Answer to yesterday's quiz:
1. Raja Street, Mandaveli
2. Parthasarathy Temple
3. Meenava Nanban

Yesterday's Winners
1. Rubal Ahuja | 2. Ashish Kumar | 3. Sanjiv Kumar

Chennai is Chenneling

APPOINTMENT

ONGC
HR/ER, CAUVERY ASSET, KARAIKAL – 609 602.
Ph. No. 04368 – 235067 / 235063

Engagement of Retired Revenue Officials on Contract Basis
Advertisement No. HRD/R&P/LAO-1/2026

ONGC, a "Maharatna" Public Sector Enterprise, intends to engage Retired Revenue Officials on contract basis at its location in Karaikal (Puducherry). Interested candidates may report for a walk-in-interview at ONGC, Cauvery Asset, Neravy Office Complex, Neravy, Karaikal - 609602, Puducherry on the following schedule. The work involves extensive field visit in and around the operational areas of ONGC as well as office work. Incumbents should be medically and physically fit for the assignment as well as possess requisite computer knowledge.

Walk-in-interview schedule:

Date	Reporting Time
20.08.2026	09:00 a.m. to 11:00 a.m.*

*Please note that candidates reporting at venue beyond 11.00 a.m. shall not be allowed for attending the Walk-in-interview

Details of the Posts, Essential Qualifications and Experience:

S. No.	Post	Remuneration per month (in Rs.)	Qualification & Experience	No. of Posts	Period of Engagement
1	Retired Deputy Collector as Associate Consultant	68,000/-	Retired Deputy collector with a minimum qualification of SSLC and at least 3 years' experience in Land Acquisition work.	01	For a period of Three years from Date of joining
2	Retired /Tahsildar/ Deputy Tahsildar/ Surveyor/ Deputy Surveyor as Junior Consultant	42,000/-	Retired Tahsildar/ Deputy Tahsildar/ Surveyor/ Deputy Surveyor with a minimum qualification of SSLC and at least 3 years' experience in Land Acquisition work.	06 (5+1*)	

*One post of Junior Consultant (Retired / Tahsildar/ Deputy Tahsildar/ Surveyor/ Deputy Surveyor) shall be released on/after the date of separation of the existing Retired Tahsildar or on/after 12.10.2026, whichever is earlier.
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Telephone Nos. 25271149, 25271151
Email: olmadras@gmail.com & ol.chennai@mcma.gov.in
Form No.63 - Rule 148(1)

IN THE HIGH COURT OF JUDICATURE AT MADRAS
ORIGINAL JURISDICTION
In the matter of M/s. MAMBALAM BENEFIT SOCIETY LIMITED
(in liquidation)
Company Application No.469/2024
in
Company petition No.149/2004

ADVERTISEMENT OF NOTICE TO CREDITORS TO PROVE THEIR CLAIM
Pursuant to the orders of Hon'ble High Court, Madras dated 29.11.2024 in C.A.No.469/2024 in C.P.No.149/2004, notice is hereby given to the creditors of the above named company that they are required to submit to the official Liquidator of the court, proofs of their respective debts or claims against the above named company by delivering at the office of the official Liquidator on or before 16.09.2026, or sending by post to the official Liquidator so as to reach him not later than the said date, an affidavit proving the debt or claim, in the prescribed form Form No.66 duly stamped and notarized with their respective names, addresses and particulars of debt or claim, in the prescribed form in Form No.66 (As per The Companies (Court) Rules,1959) duly stamped and notarized with their names, addresses and particulars of debt or claim, and any title to priority under Section 529,529A and 530. Any creditor who fails to submit his affidavit of proof within the time limited as aforesaid will be excluded from the benefit of any distribution of dividend before his /her debt is proved, or as the case may be, from objecting to such distribution.

Any creditor who has sent in his/ her proof, if so required by notice in writing from the Official Liquidator, shall either in person or by his /her advocate, attend upon the investigation of such debt or claim at such time and place as shall be specified, in such notice and shall produce such further evidence of his debt or claim as may be required.

DATED AT CHENNAI THIS THE 13th DAY OF AUGUST, 2026.

Sd/-
(V.M.PRASANTH, ICLS)
OFFICIAL LIQUIDATOR
HIGH COURT, MADRAS

Tamil Nadu

From Page One

People must develop zero tolerance for corruption, says CM

Mr. Vijay also appealed to the people of Tamil Nadu who supported him in the elections not to think that they had done their duty by voting for him and making him the Chief Minister. “Don’t think that your duty is done after making your elder brother, younger brother, your son the Chief Minister. You have to stand with us, with the government, so that we can implement all the welfare measures. People are the rulers; we are all servants. Let’s do our duty together and fight against forces and conspirators who are working against our government. I have no fear because you are all with me,” he said.

The Chief Minister also said that instructions had been given to ensure that members of the public seeking services and help from government officers were treated with respect and dignity.

‘Administrative cooperation with Centre’

The Chief Minister said that people’s welfare was the most important, and that there should be no compromises. “On that basis, we are cooperating with the Central government administratively. At the same time, the TVK government will oppose policies that go against the State’s rights and policies,” he said.

“We are continuing the policies [brought in by previous governments] that are useful for the people. For example, Amma Unavagam, brought in by Jayalithaa madam, is being continued by further making it more efficient. Similarly, the morning breakfast scheme is also continuing, and we are expanding it. The scheme will be extended from Classes 6 to 8 and will be implemented on Periyar’s birth anniversary on September 17,” he said.

Hike in assistance

He also made several announcements. In recognition of the contributions of ex-servicemen who made selfless sacrifices for the motherland and worked tirelessly for the defence of the country, the marriage assistance provided for each of their two daughters will be increased from ₹25,000 to ₹50,000, he said.

The monthly assistance for disabled ex-servicemen and their families will be increased from ₹5,000 to ₹7,000. The pension for freedom fighters has been increased to ₹23,000, and family pension has been increased to ₹12,500 per month. Monthly assistance to descendants of Vee-rapandiya Kattabomman, Mutharamalinga Vijaya-raghunatha Sethupathy, Marudhu Brothers, and V.O. Chidambaranar has been increased to ₹11,500 per month. G.Os regarding these have been published, he announced.

The Chief Minister presented the Thagaisal Thamizhar Award, the Kalpana Chawla Award for Courage and Daring Enterprise, and the Dr. A.P.J. Abdul Kalam Award, to former TNCC president M. Krishnasswamy, athlete Nausheen Banu Chand, and renowned diabetologist V. Mohan, respectively.

‘KKNPP has generated over 1.30 million units of power’

Reactors 1 and 2 of the nuclear power plant have prevented 11.22 crore tonnes of carbon dioxide emissions; both reactors are operated at capacity factors exceeding 101.5%, says Site Director

The Hindu Bureau
TIRUNELVELI

The Kudankulam Nuclear Power Plant (KKNPP), which operates two 1,000 MW VVER reactors, with four more reactors of similar capacity under construction with assistance from Russia, has so far generated 1,30,627 million units of power since its commissioning.

Addressing the Independence Day celebrations held at Anu Vijay Township on Saturday, KKNPP Site Director Ashok Bhatia said the current operational capacity factor of KKNPP Reactors 1 and 2 exceeded 101.5%.

Reactor 2 recently established a new station record for continuous operation, surpassing the previous record of 638 days held by Reactor 1. While Reactor 1 was commissioned on October 22, 2013, Reactor 2 began commercial power generation in October 15, 2016.

As on June 30, 2026, the



Long service: While Reactor 1 at Kudankulam Nuclear Power Plant was commissioned on October 22, 2013, Reactor 2 began commercial power generation in October 15, 2016. A. SHAIKMOHIDEEN

KKNPP’s first two reactors had generated 1,30,627 million units of electricity, thereby preventing 11.22 crore tonnes of carbon dioxide emissions into the atmosphere.

On the progress achieved in the construction of Reactors 3 to 6, Mr.

Bhatia said the KKNPP recently achieved the major commissioning milestone of ‘Spillage to Open Reactor’ in Reactor 3, alongside the commissioning of various systems and equipment. Recently, the reactor pressure vessel (RPV) was successfully erected inside

the reactor cavity of the building where Reactor 5 is housed.

Mr. Bhatia added that the KKNPP had so far spent ₹155.33 crore on infrastructure development in the villages around the site under its corporate social responsibility programme.

No outsiders attended T.N. Cabinet meetings, says Minister

K. Muralitharan
CHENNAI

Social Justice Minister Vanni Arasu stated that no outsiders had participated in the Tamil Nadu Cabinet meetings.

Amid allegations that John Arokiasamy and Vishnu Reddy attended the first Cabinet meeting of the Tamizhaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK)-led government, Mr. Vanni Arasu, in an exclusive interview with *The Hindu*, clarified that no such thing happened. “I was present at that Cabinet

meeting. Officials, including the Chief Secretary, came in, read out only the agenda for the meeting, and left. After that, only the Ministers were present. In both Cabinet meetings held so far, only the Ministers were seated. Neither John Arokiasamy nor Vishnu Reddy was in that meeting,” he said.

Renaming the Adi Dravida and Tribal Welfare Department as the Social Justice Department at the time of his swearing-in had sparked a controversy, with Viduthala Chiruthai



Vanni Arasu

gal Katchi (VCK) general secretary D. Ravikumar expressing his opposition. However, Mr. Vanni Arasu stated that the name change was announced on

ly on the day he took office, and whatever decision his party leader took on the matter would be final.

“In the Government of India, there is a Ministry of Social Justice, which includes departments for Backward Classes, Scheduled Castes, transpersons, and persons with disabilities. This name change might have been carried out with a similar long-term vision. Therefore, I accepted it and began my work. However, there are still differing views regarding this name change,” he

said. Addressing the continuing incidents of honour killings in Tamil Nadu and the demand for a dedicated law to prevent them, the Minister said a decision would be made only after the K.N. Basha Commission’s report was submitted.

“Members of the committee have requested a nine-month extension. Their request has been conveyed to the Chief Minister. Once the committee’s report is submitted, a swift decision will be taken,” he said. Regarding

the ongoing atrocities against Dalits across Tamil Nadu, Mr. Vanni Arasu emphasised that society bears a collective responsibility.

When asked about members within the VCK openly criticising the TVK-led government, he responded: “I do not let political criticism or remarks bother me. Our party leader told me that he will address these matters, and I should not comment on them. I will only answer questions regarding this government’s functioning.”

Creating reels is 100-day achievement of TVK-led government, says Palaniswami

The Hindu Bureau
SALEM



Edappadi K. Palaniswami

AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami said on Saturday that the 100-day achievement of the ruling TVK-led government was creating reels.

Mr. Palaniswami addressed the media at Nedunchalai Nagar in Salem after flagging off two ambulances for the Tirukoilur Assembly constituency that were bought by Tirukoilur MLA Palanisamy.

Responding to a question on a student’s murder in Coimbatore, Mr. Palaniswami condemned the tragic incident and said the government should take action against those responsible. He said a calling

attention motion was brought in the Assembly on behalf of the AIADMK, and on Monday, the government assured them that it would give complete details on the incident.

“Creating reels is the 100-day achievement of the TVK government. Likewise, the TVK-led government is facing multiple protests, including by the farmers. The TVK, which promised to waive crop loans, failed to do it. On the Mekedatu dam issue, the

government should convene an all-party meeting to hear the views of the Opposition parties and farmers,” Mr. Palaniswami said.

Regarding the investors’ meeting, Mr. Palaniswami said that most of the MoUs signed at the meeting were related to expansion of existing industries and no new big industries had been promised. “These industries were brought to the State during the AIADMK and DMK regimes,” he added.

TVK leaders condemn remarks made by Nainar Nagenthran against Chief Minister

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Leaders of the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) on Saturday condemned BJP State president Nainar Nagenthran’s remarks targeting Chief Minister and TVK leader C. Joseph Vijay, describing them as personal and unbecoming of a senior politician.

Mr. Nagenthran, addressing a political gathering, had made a personal jibe at Mr. Vijay, while re-

ferring to his remarks in the Assembly. Reacting to these comments, Revenue and Disaster Management Minister K.A. Sengottaiyan said the BJP leader’s standing in the political space was steadily declining.

Good governance

Health Minister K.G. Arunraj said the government would answer criticism through its performance rather than words. He said the government had been focusing on providing good

governance over the past three months and would continue to demonstrate its work through its policies and actions. He said Mr. Nagenthran was making such remarks out of frustration and an attempt to draw public attention.

School Education Minister P. Rajmohan also criticised Mr. Nagenthran, saying his comments were not befitting a political leader of his stature. He said public representatives should exercise restraint and

speak with dignity, particularly while holding a responsible position.

Mr. Rajmohan said the TVK would not respond to such remarks in the same manner and would continue to follow what he described as “decent politics” under Mr. Vijay’s leadership.

He added that the party would maintain this approach even if its political opponents continued to make provocative or personal remarks.

Self-financing medical, dental college fee details released

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu’s Selection Committee has put up the fee details of self-financing medical and dental colleges as a part of the ongoing counselling for MBBS/BDS courses, in compliance with the Supreme Court’s directive for mandatory pre-counselling disclosure of fees. It had directed that all private/deemed universities should mandatorily disclose their fees, detailing tuition, hostel, caution deposit, and miscellaneous charges.

Manickavel Arumugam, education counsellor, said: “It is a welcome move that

the State Selection Committee has finally released the fee details for private colleges. This transparency is highly commendable and will empower students to make informed choices. However, the disclosure still lacks clarity in a few areas. It is not clearly mentioned whether certain components are one-time charges or recurring annual fees. For example, the ‘other fees’ of ₹1,77,500 listed by one institution does not specify if it is a one-time payment or a yearly requirement.”

Among State private universities, the hostel fee ranged from ₹1,10,000 to ₹3,25,000 per year. The

fee structure in one of the institutions varies according to room type. The mess fee ranged from ₹10,000 to ₹18,000 per month. Some of these institutions also charged other fees such as development fee of ₹60,000, university fee of ₹40,000, examination fee of ₹30,000, and books/basic materials at ₹1,40,000 per year.

Among private medical colleges, the hostel fee ranged from ₹1,250 to ₹25,000 per month (depending on room type and monthly/yearly charges). The mess fee ranged from ₹9,000 to ₹22,500 per month, while it was lesser in one or two colleges.

NGT directs TNPCB to set timeline for IIT-Madras’ comprehensive study on pollution issues in Neyveli

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Southern Bench of the National Green Tribunal (NGT) has directed the Tamil Nadu Pollution Control Board (TNPCB) to issue the Terms of Reference (ToR) to IIT-Madras and fix a timeline for a comprehensive scientific study into pollution in Neyveli, after differences emerged among members of a technical committee constituted to examine the issue.

The direction was issued by the Bench comprising Justice Pushpa Sathyanarayana and expert member Prashant Gar-gava on August 12 while

hearing two *suo motu* cases based on news reports concerning alleged pollution around Neyveli Lignite Corporation (NLC) India and the presence of mercury in water. The Bench noted that the internal technical committee constituted by the TNPCB had submitted individual reports, but there were differences of opinion among its members on preparing a comprehensive report.

The TNPCB later decided to entrust the study to IIT-Madras. However, the Bench observed that the TNPCB was yet to issue the ToR to IIT-Madras or fix a timeline for completing the study.



The NGT was hearing cases based on reports concerning alleged pollution around NLC.

In its earlier order dated July 15, the Bench had recorded that the TNPCB’s sampling and analysis had produced differing findings. While private laboratory reports found mercury and selenium below the

level of quantification in the second cycle of analysis, the TNPCB’s own laboratory found mercury in six of 19 surface water samples, ranging from 0.01 mg/l to 0.027 mg/l. The Bench had noted that the heavy metals were within prescribed standards.

High-level committee

A high-level technical expert committee inspected the study area in July 2025 and collected four samples. Its members submitted individual reports but differed on the preparation of a comprehensive report. The committee had also stated that the exact source of contamination could not

be established with the available data and that a detailed investigation of hydrogeology, wind patterns, and nearby industries, including NLC, TATA, and IL&FS, would be necessary.

The Bench has asked the TNPCB to file a status report covering the ToR issued to IIT-Madras, the timeline fixed for submission of the study, and other relevant details. The matter has been posted to September 25. The Bench said that once the IIT-Madras report was filed, it could consider giving a quietus to the applications and further directions depending on the findings.

11 juveniles escape from Chengalpattu Govt. Special Home

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI



Eleven juveniles escaped from the Chengalpattu Government Special Home on Friday. The facility houses juveniles from across Tamil Nadu involved in criminal cases.

After receiving information about the escape, the Chengalpattu Town police visited the home and began an inquiry to identify the juveniles and ascertain their native places. Chengalpattu District Superintendent of Police Ayman Jamal also visited the facility and conducted an inspection.

The special home, which has been functioning since the British era, has reportedly witnessed repeated incidents of juveniles assaulting staff members, including cooks and security guards, before escaping.

In the last eight months, juveniles have allegedly assaulted security guards and escaped on three occasions.

Following the latest incident, more than 100 police

In the last eight months, juveniles allegedly assaulted guards and escaped from the home on three occasions.

personnel from the Chengalpattu Armed Reserve, Chengalpattu Town, Chengalpattu Taluk, Palur and Padalam police stations have been deployed to assist with security and search operations.

Staff at the home have been seeking round-the-clock security, with police personnel deployed in shifts, citing the repeated incidents of juveniles escaping from the facility.

A senior police officer said, “After receiving the complaint from the staff, we have duly registered a case and quickly launched an investigation. The juveniles allegedly stole a key from a home guard during dinner time and escaped.”

Classifieds

LIFE MADE SIMPLE

THE HINDU

SITUATIONS VACANT

INDEX OF SITUATIONS VACANT	GENERAL
ACCOUNTS & FINANCE	BACKOFFICE EXEC Word Excel Law Firm @ Kodambakkam.9840068416/960002876
BPO	REOD FEMALE Tally Op to Coord Dispatch & Tele Followup Hardwire Shp in Parys Stry 18-22K Wsap. 8248405706
COURIER	M/s Front Line Ex-Servicemen Bureau. Requires 1 Personnel on contract at ICMAI, SIRC, Montesh Lane, Egmore, Chennai-600008. 044-2855 4443 / 044-2852 8219
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GROOM WANTED Naidu,27yrs, Divorce, MBBS, MS,Well Educated Family in Chennai Ph:6385293227

GROOM WANTED Rich Mudaliar,27yrs, MBBS, MS,Well Educated family in Chennai Ph:7200187009

GROOM WANTED Hindu Nadar 28yrs,BE,SWE,1.5L p/m, well educated family Ph:9841329471, 9380791999

HINDU, MBC, Divorce 38,M.tech. Caste no bar. Seeking a suitable Groom. Call : 99524 38211 / 73588 24670

✓ ALLIANCE INVITED for 26 year-old, Tamil, SC, well educated, postgraduate daughter, working with a leading corporate law firm dealing in Capital Markets, advising reputed companies and banks on IPOs and major financial transactions. Intelligent, family-oriented with a modern outlook and strong values. Seeking a well-educated, professionally accomplished groom, from a respectable family. Ph 9444415358

MUDHALIYAR, MBA, Entrepreneur. Looking for a groom from 28-33 in same caste from Rich/affluent family, 8138900412

MUDALIYAR, RICH/AFFLUENT, Divorced, MA, Business, 49, looking for good looking profile from 48yrs, 8138900312

PILLAI, MD, 30, looking for a groom from 30-35 from TN and Karnataka.Highly educated.8137003516

SC, NRI, Nursing, Good, looking for any European countries or relocate profile groom from any caste or religion, 8137001255

HINDU NADAR-- Divorcee Unconsummated Marriage-35 Accenture UK Ltd London.UK Cyber Security Associate Manager,Seeks Blw 39yr Cal/WA 9442126376

TAMIL

46 YRS /165 cm, Smartha Iyer, BE MS, Divorcee from short marriage, working in reputed MNC seeking issueless, professionally qualified vegetarian groom, 45-51, never married / divorced, earning 40L+ p.a. WhatApp: 9500015455

BRAHMIN, 25, lyengar, MBBS, seeking for a brahmin groom from 25-32, well-educated and well settled including NRI, 8137003550

VANNIYAR Chettiar, 29 yrs beautiful, C.A.working in MNC Bangalore. We prefer Hindu Groom with C.A/Financial Executive/H.M.E.M.Tech only working in Bangalore or Chennai Tamil speaking Non-Vegetarian from Chettiar Mudaliar and Pillai.Please send horoscope & other details only to WhatsApp-No.9444587465.

Tamil, Good Family 29Yrs, B.Tech, MBA (BIM), 26 LPA, seeks suitable Groom, CNB. Contact: 9441677205.

Tamil, Good Family, 26Yrs, B.Sc(OU), UMC, Fair Girl seeks suitable Groom, CNB. Contact: 9441677205.

SC, NRI, Nursing, Good, looking for any European countries or relocate profile groom from any caste or religion, 8137001255

HINDU NADAR-- Divorcee Unconsummated Marriage-35 Accenture UK Ltd London.UK Cyber Security Associate Manager,Seeks Blw 39yr Cal/WA 9442126376

TELUGU

VB TELUGU bride, 1992, 5'6", fair, M.A., working in Digital Media. Seeks Telugu groom, 34 to 37 yrs, 5'9" above. Ph: 9866970713 / 8106366930.

NAIDU 26/168, Fair, Beautiful, B.Tech, Tech Lead, Wipro, 2500000 PA, Affluent, CNB, 9043991629, 9043987029

KAMMA (ANY-TELUGU) 28/ V.Fair & Beautiful, Under graduation, Running Own Boutique, Chennai, Elite Family, Seeks Groom Business / Job-Ct: 8608626666

SC, 35 YEARS / 152cm, Pharm.D, PhD, Divorce, No kids, seeks Groom- India & abroad, caste no bar. Cont.9700019949.

URDU

SUNNI MUSLIM 27y 171cms B'tul Doctor Girl doing DM Endocrinology If affluent family. Seck Doc/Professional q'lfid match. WA/call 949871312

SUNNI MUSLIM girl, 1994 born, 164 cm, B.Tech, working in PSU Bank, Mumbai. Well-educated family from UP; father retired Adtl. Director. Seeks suitable match. #9461179587

BRIDES WANTED

COSMOPOLITAN

SMART, SUCCESSFUL 44, well-read professional. Never-married. Seeks well-educated compatible bride. Caste/language no bar. Call/WA 9345634365

ENGINEER

Railway Senior Section Engineer Thiyya (Kerala) 34 Years, seeks Bride Contact - 9495891105

HINDI

1985/175CM, 50 Lakhs PA, Never Married, Bangalore. WhatsApp: 96290 12248

MALAYALAM

RC BOY, 39/180, SSE, Railways, Eranakulam, girls above 35 years working in Kerala preferred. Send Bio-Data to 9495269815.

Alliance invited for Hindu Nair groom, 32/168, NIFT, M.Sc. (Saxton), well-settled professional in the Netherlands, never married. Seeking educated, family-oriented Hindu Nair bride. Horoscope preferred. Contact:7012904828.

SAURASTRA

SAURASHTRA, 40, 1st Marriage, Ashram, Kann, MBA, Finance, Senior Manager, Pvt, Chennai 1.50 Lakhs pm, Seeks Suitable Bride. CNB. 9381725577

TAMIL

CHRISTIAN TAMIL 44/175cm BE, MBA Australia MNC, Divorcee No issues, seeks suitable Bride. Ct: 9094677765

CHRISTIAN NADAR, Doctor, MBBS, PGDCC-P (NI), Cardio - Physician, Divorcee issueless, 38yrs/178cm, lives in Nagercoil seeks qualified / divorced bride. Ct: 90039 83230

RC CHRISTIAN, 43yrs/170, B.E. Software Engineer, never married, works for mnc, Chennai. CT- 9500188067

AUDITOR/ 47 Chennai/ Seeks Any Vegetarian Hindu Girl. Contact : 9884398109

BRIDE WANTED Rc Nadar 32yrs.B.Tech, SWE 1lp/m, educated family Ph:9380791999,9841329471

BRIDE WANTED Mudaliyar,26yrs,BE, Elite business family in Chennai Ph: 6385293227

BRIDE WANTED Naidu, 32yrs,MBA, Own Constructions,Elite business family in Chennai Ph:9952619776

BRIDE WANTED Mudaliyar, 28yrs.B.Tech,Elite business family in Chennai Ph: 9384772710

NAIDU GROOM Aug 81 born Surgeon BDS & UK MBA seek suitable compatible PQ DR Engr or IT working in India or Abroad CNB. Groom working in Bang as CEO of Hospital. 98867 82390/ 99622 46305

BRIDE WANTED for Yadava, Konar boy 1998/190cm B.Tech,MBA, handsome, clean habits, Bangalore based, currently working as VP in JPNC, USA. Open to come back to India, seeks bride from same cast, bangalore based or educated in bangalore. Reply with horoscope, photograph. Ct: 9880343417.ramakrishnan737@gmail.com

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needed for a neurodivergent Child We are looking for a caring, patience and experienced teacher to provide one-on-one homeschooling support for our neurodivergent son

Ct: 98848 83699

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✓ WANTED Music Teacher, Clerk, Apply in person. V.O.C MHS School 24/ 66 BBRoad Perambur. vocmatric@yahoo.com

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KG: Coordinator / Experienced Montessori Trained Teachers

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A palace with an exclusive gallery of Lord Nataraja idols

31 bronze idols, including that of Sivakami, the consort of Nataraja, is housed at Thanjavur Palace; these date from 11th to 19th Centuries and were recovered from parts of erstwhile Thanjavur district

B. Kolappan
CHENNAI

“The dance of Shiva at Chidambaram, or Thillai, forms the central motif of the south Indian bronze images of Shri Nataraja, the Lord of the Dance,” writes Indologist Ananda Coomaraswamy in his classic work *The Dance of Shiva*. “These images vary amongst themselves in minor details, but all express one fundamental conception,” he observes. Cosmic activity is the central theme of the dance.

A visit to the Nataraja Hall in the Thanjavur Palace complex reveals bronze idols of Lord Nata-

raja dating from the 11th to 19th Centuries, each embodying, in its own way, the conception described by Coomaraswamy.

The gallery houses 31 bronze idols, including images of Sivakami (Uma), the consort of Nataraja. Varying in size and style, the idols were recovered from different parts of the erstwhile Thanjavur district.

“These idols were earlier part of the palace museum. In 2024, the then District Collector, Deepak Jacob, using funds from the art gallery and support received through the Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) initiative of Saint-Gobain Glass, established a dedicated museum to showcase the different

forms of Nataraja and highlight the unique artistic features of each image,” said S. Elaiyaraja, the museum’s curator. The gallery was inaugurated in the same year.

Unique exhibits

No two Nataraja idols in the gallery are identical, even though they conform to the same iconographic tradition. Nataraja is depicted wearing a man’s earring in his right ear and a woman’s earring in his left, symbolising the union of the masculine and feminine elements. He wore what Thevaram describes as a *kumizh sirippu*.

One of his right hands holds the *udukkai* or damukku (drum), symbolis-



Masterpieces: A bronze idol of Lord Nataraja is displayed at the Nataraja Hall in Thanjavur Palace. R. VENGADESH

ing creation, while the other is raised in the *abhaya mudra*, the gesture of reassurance and protection. In one of his left hands, he holds a flame, representing destruction, while the other points towards the

dwarf demon *Muyalaka*, who lies beneath his feet clutching a cobra. His raised left foot signifies liberation and divine grace.

The deity stands upon a lotus pedestal, encircled by the flaming *tiruvasi*,

whose ring of fire symbolises the cosmos and the eternal cycle of creation, preservation, and dissolution.

In the gallery, some Nataraja idols retain their *tiruvasi*, while others are displayed without it. Their hand gestures and hairstyles also vary.

Another striking exhibit is the Nataraja from Tirukollampudur, a temple celebrated in the *Thevaram* hymns. Yet another idol from Thanjavur depicts the *Oordhva Tandava*, with Shiva raising one leg high towards the sky. The bronzes from Tiruvenkadu and Muthupet stand as fine examples of Chola-period bronze craftsmanship, a tradition that continues to

flourish in the region.

The idols were created using the lost-wax casting technique.

Historian and epigraphist R. Nagaswamy, in his book *Masterpieces of Chola Art*, notes that three metals – gold, silver, and copper – were regarded as sacred for use in religious rituals. The inscriptions of King Rajaraja I in the Brihadisvara Temple at Thanjavur refer to images made from all three metals. There is also a reference to a brass image, but nowhere do the inscriptions mention bronze images.

An examination of early and later idols shows that copper constituted more than 93% of early images, whereas in later idols,

from about the 14th Century onwards, the copper content fell to around 85%. “So the term bronze applied to Indian metal images is a misnomer,” he writes.

In later periods, sculptors increasingly used an alloy of five metals – copper, tin, lead, gold, and silver – known as *Panchaloha*. Mr. Elaiyaraja said many of the bronzes in the gallery have borne the ravages of time and suffered damage. “Some of the idols were handed over to the government by Shai-vite mutts after they were damaged (*pinnamathal*)”, he explained.

For the full story, visit: <https://newsth.live/NatarajaGallery>

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I, RAHAMATH NISHA Born on 29/02/ 1980 W/o. Santhana Beeroli, Residing at 309, 2nd Block, 3rd Main Road, KKD Nagar, Kodungaiyur, Chennai-600118 Shall henceforth be known as S RAHAMATH NISHA

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CM YK

M CH-CE



N. Murali, Chairman, The Hindu Group Publishing Private Limited, and N. Ram, Director, THGPPL, launching The Hindu 360 Tamil YouTube channel in the presence of Nirmala Lakshman, Director, THGPPL, in Chennai on Saturday. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

Live now: Tamil YouTube channel ‘The Hindu 360’

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Hindu 360, the Tamil YouTube channel of *The Hindu*, was launched on Saturday.

N. Murali, Chairman, The Hindu Group Publishing Private Limited (THGPPL), and N. Ram, Director, THGPPL, launched the channel in the presence of Nirmala Lakshman, Director, THGPPL, and Suresh Nambath, Editor, *The Hindu*.

Mr. Ram said that it is a landmark initiative, and added that videos in Hindi are also being done.

“We are [giving viewers good content] after exten-

sive research. Investigative journalism should reach the Tamil audience too,” he said. The Editor, Suresh Nambath, and his team have taken the initiative to start the channel with the support from L.V. Navaneeth, CEO, The Hindu Group, and the digital team, he said.

“This initiative will work well. I hope public benefit from the channel,” he added.

Mr. Nambath said that this channel is an effort towards reaching more users in formats of their choice.

Link to the YouTube channel: [newsth.live/the-hindu360](https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCnewsth360) or search for @TheHinduOfficial360.

INBRIEF



3 students hurt in ABVP-NSUI clash at Hyderabad’s EFLU

The clash between Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) and National Students’ Union of India (NSUI) members at the English and Foreign Languages University (EFLU) campus in Hyderabad has escalated into a police case involving 14 students, with three students sustaining serious head injuries. The police have booked cases against members of both groups.

Caste abuses by politicians carry graver indignity: HC

When a politician or their legions hurl casteist abuses at a member of the Scheduled Castes or Scheduled Tribes community in a public place, the indignity assumes a graver dimension, said the Karnataka High Court. The court made the observations while refusing to discharge Sirajuddin, former Congress MLA, in a 2023 case.

Telangana SIR leaves fate of 94 lakh electors uncertain

After draft rolls are published tomorrow, 119 EROs will have 60 days to issue notices and conduct hearings; BLOs’ door-to-door visits to explain the enumeration process largely did not happen

Swathi Vadlamudi
HYDERABAD

After August 17, the date of publication of draft electoral rolls in Telangana, Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) will have to conduct hearings for the verification of close to 94 lakh voters within two months. Of these, more than 32 lakh are those who did not fill in their details from the final electoral rolls of 2002 SIR as required in the Enumeration Forms. They have all been categorised as unmapped voters, officials said.

Door-to-door visits by Booth-Level Officers, which could have helped voters understand the pro-



BLOs verify voter details during the SIR exercise in the Sangareddy district of Telangana. FILE PHOTO

cess, did not happen in many instances. In many localities, BLOs confined themselves to distributing and collecting forms from a central location instead of visiting households. Electoral officials had repeatedly said BLOs must

visit each household thrice – to distribute the forms, explain how to fill them in, and collect them. However, the BLOs could not meet these targets.

Of the total forms submitted at the end of the Enumeration Phase, a total of

61.4 lakh logical discrepancies were reportedly discovered. When clubbed with the number of unmapped electors, nearly 94 lakh electors will have to be served notices for hearings.

The notice period will begin on Monday and will continue up to October 15, 2026, leaving the EROs 60 days to issue notices and conduct hearings. Even if the notices are served within the first fortnight, it would leave 45 days for hearings. With 119 EROs endowed with quasi-judicial powers set to adjudicate cases, they may be left with less than a minute’s time to verify each elector even if they work 24 hours a day.

3 ‘poachers’ killed in shoot-out at Hanur

The Hindu Bureau
MYSURU

Three suspected poachers were killed in an alleged exchange of fire with Forest Department personnel in the Chikkallur Reserved Forest area of the Cauvery Wildlife Division in Hanur taluk of Chamarajanagar district, Karnataka early on Saturday.

Tension prevailed in Hanur, with relatives and local residents allegedly ran-

sacking the DRFO office, claiming that the deceased were innocent and demanding action against the personnel involved in the shoot-out. A magisterial enquiry has been ordered into the deaths and the incidents that followed.

The Forest Department claimed to have seized two country-made guns and four bags from the spot. Forest Minister Ramalinga Reddy later said the bags contained deer meat.

No clarity on PRCs for SIR verification

Rishita Khanna
BENGALURU

With the enumeration phase of the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) set to end on Monday, the Karnataka Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) is yet to indicate whether the Permanent Residential Certificate (PRC) that the Election Commission of India (EC) itself lists as an indicative document will actually be accepted in the State.

Clarity on this issue is particularly important for voters who would be flagged for logical discrepancies in their enumeration forms and the over 28 lakh ‘unmapped’ voters. Following the release of the draft electoral roll, these voters will be asked to submit one of the 11 documents as per the EC’s list.

Karnataka CEO V. Anbu Kumar said that he would provide clarity over PRCs “later”.

Kerala CM warns against communalism, calls for democracy founded on open-mindedness

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Democracy is not about creating a “single type of human being in a monoculture plantation”, nurturing one language, one belief, and one lifestyle. Kerala Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan said on Saturday. It is also not about creating islets of hatred and darkness of communalism, Mr. Satheesan said in his address after hoisting the national flag during the Independence Day celebrations in Thiruvananthapuram.

Mr. Satheesan called



Kerala Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan inspects the Independence Day parade at Central Stadium in Thiruvananthapuram on Saturday. PTI

upon people to become “guardians and fighters of a strong democracy founded on open-mindedness, tolerance and debate...”

“That is the biggest salute to the great heroes of our freedom struggle, including Mahatma Gandhi, Subhas Chandra Bose,

Bhagat Singh, Bal Gangadhar Tilak and Gopal Krishna Gokhale,” he said.

No Vande Mataram

Notably, *Vande Mataram* was not sung at the function despite the Union government’s direction.

Referring to the alleged purification ritual performed at a rally venue in Uttarakhand after a senior Congress leader addressed a gathering there, Mr. Satheesan said even “a prominent national leader who has spent decades in politics and held constitutional positions was being insulted on the grounds of caste

and untouchability.”

“If such attempts are made, it is our duty and responsibility to oppose them to the hilt. Each of us must work with utmost care and caution to protect our Constitution and the fundamental principles it guarantees,” he said.

“This is the time when we must stand together, without compromise, for constitutional principles and the unity, integrity and secularism of India,” he said.

Mr. Satheesan also called upon people to pledge themselves to building “a new-era Kerala”.

A.P. CM calls for resolve to build ‘Swarna Andhra’

Sambasiva Rao M.
AMARAVATI

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu on Saturday called upon people to make a collective resolve to transform the State into Swarna Andhra by 2047, aligning the goal with Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s Viksit Bharat vision.

Mr. Naidu hoisted the national flag during the 80th Independence Day celebrations held at the Parade Ground in Amaravati.

He recalled the sacrifices of Mahatma Gandhi, Subhas Chandra Bose, Bhagat Singh, Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, B.R. Ambedkar and other freedom fighters. He highlighted the contribution of Telugu leaders, including Alluri Sitarama Raju and Pingali Venkayya.

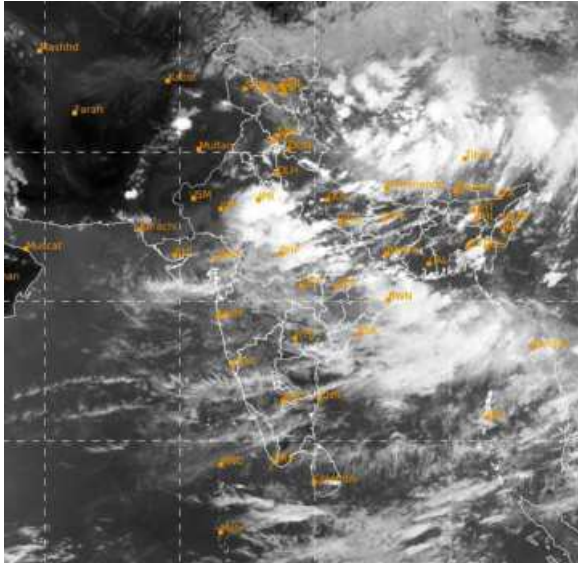
Calling for an “I am” commitment, Mr. Naidu urged citizens to think about what they could contribute to the nation rather than merely claiming their rights. Students should pursue innovation, farmers should adopt nature-friendly agriculture, employees should discharge their responsibilities and women should seize opportunities for empowerment, he said.

He said Andhra Pradesh has overcome repeated challenges, including State formation, bifurcation and the ‘economic setbacks of 2019-24’.

Mr. Naidu said the Swarna Andhra 2047 vision focused on a “Healthy, Wealthy and Happy A.P.”, with 10 priorities covering poverty eradication, employment, skills, water security, agri-tech, logistics and energy.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 17.00 HRS)

Forecast for Sunday: Heavy to very heavy rainfall very likely at isolated places over Arunachal Pradesh, and Odisha. Thunderstorm accompanied with lightning very likely at isolated places over Assam, Meghalaya, Bihar, and Chhattisgarh. Strong surface winds very likely at isolated places over Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, and Telangana.

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala	3.6	35.3	25.6	Kurnool	31.6	33.8	24.7
Ahmedabad	2.3	31.9	26.2	Lucknow	3.8	35.5	27.2
Aizawl	70.0	33.0	22.3	Madurai	4.0	37.5	26.1
Bengaluru	0.5	29.0	20.5	Mangaluru	13.1	28.8	23.8
Bhopal	0.6	27.9	23.3	Mumbai	7.2	32.2	24.4
Bhubaneswar	42.6	31.0	26.0	Mysuru	—	30.0	19.6
Chandigarh	33.8	32.4	24.8	New Delhi	5.8	30.5	26.0
Chennai	11.0	37.6	26.4	Patna	0.3	34.5	28.3
Coimbatore	—	32.0	21.6	Port Blair	—	32.0	25.2
Dehradun	8.0	31.9	24.2	Prayagraj	—	34.6	26.4
Gangtok	14.9	24.6	18.5	Puducherry	—	—	27.5
Goa	2.8	31.5	25.8	Pune	—	37.7	28.2
Guwahati	0.2	36.1	27.3	Raipur	—	3.6	27.8
Hubballi	—	27.0	21.0	Ranchi	—	13.0	29.2
Hyderabad	—	31.8	24.0	Shillong	—	—	26.3
Imphal	—	32.5	23.1	Shimla	—	6.6	26.5
Jaipur	—	33.0	27.6	Srinagar	—	—	32.0
Kochi	21.6	29.8	24.0	Thiruvananthapuram	—	31.1	18.5
Kohima	—	—	—	Tiruchirappalli	—	—	37.3
Kolkata	3.1	33.4	27.6	Vijayawada	—	—	—
Kozhikode	0.1	32.0	25.4	Visakhapatnam	1.0	32.5	27.0

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing

CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM _{2.5}	PM ₁₀	CODE	Yesterday
Ahmedabad	10	32	11	—	57	110	In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Leh, Ladakh
Bengaluru	9	108	35	10	—	—	recorded an overall air quality index (AQI) score of 184 indicating an unhealthy level of pollution. In contrast, Madikeri, Karnataka recorded a healthy AQI score of 14
Chennai	3	12	30	208	115	102	
Delhi	10	12	30	—	208	115	
Hyderabad	12	15	33	45	—	66	
Kolkata	20	23	33	76	—	91	
Lucknow	37	12	25	39	114	115	
Mumbai	—	19	73	30	—	45	
Pune	—	23	86	46	—	62	
Visakhapatnam	19	80	16	39	—	72	

Air Quality Code: ■ Poor ■ Moderate ■ Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH



E. David

(61 years) has gone to be with the Lord on 15th August 2026. He has touched many lives with his warmth and kindness. He is deeply loved and will be profoundly missed by those who had the privilege of knowing him.

Funeral, to be held on **Monday, 17th August**

His mortal remains are kept for viewing at his residence

Residential Address : Raybel House, 4/448A 14th link street, Venkateshwara nagar, Judges Colony, Kottivakkam CMR Ch-41
Contact Nos. 9940045755, 7558524089, 9940055755

DEATH

LALITHA RANGARAJAN (91 yrs) w/o Late K Rangarajan (Thangam) passed away on 15.08.2026 Contact Dr. Venkatasubramanian 9940049327, Adhisri Apartments, Kothari Road, Nungambakkam

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

FORTY THIRD ANNIVERSARY



Mrs. ROSILY JACOB

09.02.1945 - 16.08.1983

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DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

In Revered Memory of

Suresh Bapalal Mehta & Varsha S. Mehta



20.08.2005 - 16.08.2013

We bow in reverence to our benevolent mentors and follow the path illuminated by their wisdom.

SHEETAL BHAT, VINOD BHAT, VIRAJ & SHAKTI and staff members of

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DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

FOURTH ANNIVERSARY



SHRI HAREESH CHAND AGARWAL

Oct 8, 1939 - Aug 16, 2022

On your fourth anniversary, we pause to honour a life filled with love, integrity and compassion. Your guidance continues to inspire us, your blessings give us strength and your memories remain a constant source of comfort. Though you are deeply missed everyday, your legacy will forever live in our hearts.

Always Loved. Always Remembered

Smt. Anuradha Rani Agarwal
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From Page One

PM Modi warns against ‘intellectual Naxals’

“For years, people with a Maoist ideology had established themselves in the corridors of power and influenced policymaking, including as advisers on government committees” the Prime Minister said. “They are trying to revive the paths of violence and anarchy, and are making various attempts to drag society in the wrong direction. We must identify these intellectual Naxalites and isolate them. At the same time, we must connect the country’s young generation with the mainstream effort to build a developed nation,” he added.

He announced a full review and restructuring of civil defence infrastructure. “The nature of warfare is changing. There is no guarantee that wars will now be fought only along the borders,” the Prime Minister said. “A new form of warfare is emerging... Attacks can target a refinery, the banking sector, or a data centre. Infrastructure can be destroyed and factories can be targeted. We had announced Mission Sudarshan Chakra, [a multi-layered defence infrastructure system, with AI and cybersecurity components] last year, and work on it is going on rapidly,” he added.

A large part of the Prime Minister’s speech was devoted to what he termed ‘*Saptadhara*’ or the seven economic streams where his government was committed to reforms for growth. This includes manufacturing power with emphasis on quality; agriculture and food processing; technology and innovation as evidenced by the opening of the private sector for space exploration, and operationalisation of seven or eight semiconductor plants in the next year or two; the PM Gatishakti plan for multi-modal connectivity; enhanced domestic capabilities in armament production; a green and blue economy; and the projection of India’s soft power, including via yoga, tourism, and animation.

Mr. Modi recalled that, when he had first promoted his ‘Make in India’ initiative, advocates of globalisation had reacted as though it was heresy. In the current global economy, however, every country is thinking for itself, he pointed out.

The government has targeted the creation of 100 GW of nuclear energy capacity by 2047, Mr. Modi said, adding that five new reactors will be made operational in the next six to seven years.

Farmers, police clash in Haryana during protest

“There was so much crowd at that time. To disperse them... to keep them away, police also had to do it,” the SP said.

The All-India Kisan Sabha (AIKS) Haryana State Committee condemned the police action, alleging that protesters were subjected to a lathi charge and that several people were arrested at different entry points to Hansi. AIKS national vice-president Inderjit Singh demanded the immediate release of the arrested leaders, the return of the impounded vehicles, and the arrest of the accused in Kundu’s murder. Opposition leaders also criticised the police action.

Five killed amid heavy rainfall in Arunachal

The four workers killed in Upper Subansiri were identified as Tadu Baki, Taji Rai, Markosh Basumatari, and Babul Ali. Officials said only Ali’s body was recovered before the search was suspended due to operational constraints by Friday evening. They were working on a project under the Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana.

In Anini, teams from the Army’s 5th Grenadier, the Indo-Tibetan Border Police’s 58th Battalion, 62 Road Construction Company of the General Reserve Engineer Force, the State police, and local volunteers joined the search operation.

The death of the woman Sarti occurred when a light commercial pick-up truck fell off the road into Lohit river at around 6 a.m. The Anjaw DDMO said the vehicle plunged about 300 feet below the road running along a cliff. While six people were rescued, a woman was confirmed dead, and three others were missing, an official said.

BCI chief apologises for ‘hurting’ students

The BCI chief focused on the concerns raised by students and stressed that their views should be heard with patience, sensitivity, and respect. He emphasised that law students are capable of forming their own views and should not be subjected to pressure or influence.

Acknowledging that protests are an important part of democracy, Mr. Mishra said that students must always remain free to express their views.

“At the same time, the legal tradition teaches us something equally important, namely that when further facts or clarifications emerge, every issue should be reconsidered objectively and with an open mind. There is no inconsistency between expressing a genuine grievance and thereafter fairly considering a clarification,” he added. Describing convocation ceremonies as important milestones, Mr. Mishra said the choice of whether to attend must rest entirely with the students, adding that no student should be forced either to participate or to stay away.

Bar and Bench committed to your growth, CJI tells youth

The Chief Justice’s message comes after Bar Council’s attempt to stop professional enrolment of 2026 batch of NALSAR University students; he praises the youth’s resilience and social awareness

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Chief Justice of India, Surya Kant, in his Independence Day address at the Supreme Court on Saturday, said the younger generation’s “remarkable resilience”, awareness of social realities, and their use of technology to communicate and access knowledge give the nation every reason to be confident in them.

“This generation brings with it qualities that give us every reason to be confident. They have grown up in a world where technology has transformed the way we communicate and access knowledge, and they are bringing that adaptability into the courtroom. At the same time, they bring a greater awareness of the social realities around them,” Chief Justice Kant said, referring to young law graduates and lawyers.

Young lawyers show deep sensitivity to questions of equality, inclusion and access to justice, and with an understanding that the law must remain connected to the lives and aspirations of the people it



CJI Surya Kant hoists the National Flag during the 80th Independence Day celebrations at the Supreme Court. PTI

serves, the Chief Justice said.

“To our young law graduates and young lawyers, I want to say this – the responsibility that this Bar has carried since the days of the freedom struggle will, before long, rest on your shoulders. The institutions of justice that generations before you have built and strengthened are now yours to protect and to carry forward. Please know that the Bar and the Bench remain committed to your growth – by extending mentorship, by creating meaningful opportunity, and by placing our confidence in you. The miles that remain are yours to walk, and we walk with

you,” Chief Justice Kant said.

Chief Justice Kant’s focus in his Independence Day address on the younger generation of law graduates and lawyers came after the Bar Council of India’s (BCI) half-baked move to stop the professional enrolment of the entire 2026 batch of NALSAR (National Academy of Legal Studies and Research) University of Law graduates.

The BCI’s actions had invited public ire, followed by condemnation from the Supreme Court itself.

Chief Justice Kant, in an oral mention of a petition against the BCI on Friday, had upheld the students’

right to protest. The CJI had said in open court that the students’ objection to his coming to their convocation ceremony as chief guest was part of a “dialogue” between them and him, and the BCI had no business bargaining in.

The Chief Justice had protected NALSAR students and faculty from any punitive action by the BCI. The top judge had even urged the graduates to enrol with the Supreme Court Bar and take up legal aid work.

‘More competitive’
The Chief Justice commended the younger generation for their “remarkable resilience”.

The challenges in law and life were far greater today than were faced by earlier generations, the top judge said.

“The profession is more competitive today, the learning curve has become steeper, and the pressures of building a practice weigh heavily in these early years. And yet, I have also seen in our young colleagues a remarkable resilience, a sharp intellect, and a genuine commitment to justice,” Chief Justice Kant said.

Youth can become a burden without jobs, skills: Bhagwat

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

India’s young population could become a powerful engine of growth if nurtured properly, said Rashtriya Swayamsewak Sangh (RSS) chief Mohan Bhagwat on Saturday, warning that it could also become a burden if the youth were not properly equipped, employed and guided.

Speaking to young people at an event organised by the Lokmat Media Group to mark the 80th Independence Day in Nagpur, Mr. Bhagwat described India’s youth as a “demographic dividend”.

“If the youth are nurtured well, they can become an asset for the nation and help the country realise its ambition of becoming a “Vishwaguru” (world leader), but if not, they could become a burden on society,” he said.

Distinct strategy
He asserted that India should develop an approach suited to its own circumstances rather than measure its progress by comparing itself with countries such as the U.S., China, Australia, New Zealand and Canada. “India needs to establish its own benchmarks for progress



Mohan Bhagwat

after studying its challenges carefully,” he said, adding that the country’s large population, limited geographical space and different resource base require a distinct development strategy.

The event marked Mr. Bhagwat’s second interaction with Gen Z in ten days. On August 6, he had defended young people protesting against irregularities in the NEET paper leak, saying their grievances were genuine and that protesting did not make them “anti-national”.

At another Independence Day event at Kasturba Park in Nagpur, the RSS chief said democracy allows for diverse ideas and ways for expressing them. He emphasised that dialogue, debate and the exchange of arguments are essential to the democratic process.

Protesters take out ‘Tiranga Yatra’ in Ranchi on day 22; CM Soren vows ‘systemic change’

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

Jharkhand Chief Minister Hemant Soren on Saturday used his Independence Day address to assure students that their hard work would not be left at the mercy of any mafia, corrupt systems or question paper leaks as the protest in Ranchi against irregularities in State government recruitment exams entered its 22nd day.

Hundreds of protesting students and job aspirants took out a “Tiranga (Tricolour) Yatra” in Ranchi city. They have been demanding an inquiry by the CBI and action against those responsible for alleged irregularities in competitive exams for government jobs in the State, including in the JPSC Examination and the Jharkhand General Graduate Level Combined Competitive Examination.

Mr. Soren, while addressing a gathering at Mo-



An aerial view of job aspirants and students taking out a 'Tiranga Yatra' during their protest against irregularities in Jharkhand government recruitment exams, in Ranchi on Saturday. PTI

rabadi Ground in Ranchi after hoisting the Tricolour, promised “systemic change” and described Jharkhand’s youth as its greatest asset as the State looks to grow over the next 25 years.

“Today, I want to assure every student in Jharkhand that your hard work will

not be left at the mercy of any mafia, corrupt system, or irregularities,” Mr. Soren said. Promising an impartial investigation into the issues, the Chief Minister said, “The law will deal sternly with anyone found guilty. No matter how influential a person may be, if their involvement is pro-

ven, they will not be spared.”

Mr. Soren promised a time-bound annual examination calendar, a transparent examination system secured with the help of technology, timely availability of answer keys and OMR sheets, and multi-level accountability within

the examination process. However, the protesters have said they would not withdraw the stir until the government addresses their demands, including cancellation of examinations in which alleged irregularities were found.

Call for gherao
Demanding Mr. Soren’s resignation, JPSC-JSSC Reforms Manch leader Ravindra Paswan said, “We will gherao the Chief Minister’s residence on August 20. We seek his resignation as both the JMM and the Congress are playing politics with us. We also demand that Congress leader Rahul Gandhi withdraw support to the JMM-led coalition if the Chief Minister is not listening to him”. The protesters also said that they would burn effigies of the Chief Minister and Congress leader Rahul Gandhi across all 24 districts on Sunday. (With PTI inputs)

External forces behind Gen Z protest: Odisha CM

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi on Saturday reiterated his earlier stand, saying external forces were behind the Gen Z protest, which was critical of the BJP government over its education policy.

“Over the past few days, certain external forces, both within and outside the country, have been attempting to mislead the youth of the nation,” said Mr. Majhi, addressing the 80th Independence Day event in Bhubaneswar. Prime Minister Narendra Modi will not compromise an inch for the nation’s interests, he added.

CJP founder launches a campaign to set right school education system

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI/JAIPUR

Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) founder Abhijeet Dipke began the “School theek karo” (fix the school) campaign at a government school in his native village of Santuk Pimpri in Hingoli district of Maharashtra.

“People have now understood that they should talk about education, which is the need of the hour. No matter which political party ruled, nobody worked for government schools in States. Now there is a need, and we can make them work by asking questions,” Mr. Dipke said, after interacting with the students. Comparing the money spent on political



CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke interacting with students at a Zilla Parishad school in Santuk Pimpri village in Maharashtra. PTI

banners on the Tiranga campaign with those spent for schools, he said that “Had this money been spent on schools and students in rural areas, it would have been even better. They should think

about the future of school students.”

Rajasthan protest
About 50 activists of the CJP, led by its co-convenor Ashutosh Ranka, joined a protest by students and lo-

cal residents at a government school in Rajasthan’s Alwar district against the dilapidated condition of the school and a shortage of teaching staff.

The Government Senior Secondary School at Jodha was had seen a slab fall from its roof earlier this week. Moreover, five of the six senior teachers’ posts in the school are vacant.

Addressing the protesters, Mr. Ranka said there were about 84,000 classrooms in Rajasthan that were in dilapidated conditions, putting the future of 15 lakh children at risk. “If the BJP government fails to repair these classrooms, it should brace itself for the largest protest in the State’s history,” he said.

Devendra Mahto alleges assault by Ranchi police

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

Jharkhand Loktantrik Krantikari Morcha (JLKM) leader Devendra Nath Mahto, who has been undergoing treatment at Ranchi Sadar Hospital, rebuked the Ranchi police for stopping him when he tried to take part in the Tiranga Yatra organised by the protesting students on the occasion of 80th Independence Day.

Mr. Mahto, who is leading the faction of JPSC-JSSC Nyay Manch, has been on a hunger strike for the past 14 days in support of the demands raised by the students over alleged irregularities in the recruitment examination in Jharkhand.

When the police did not allow him to leave the room where he was admitted, an altercation took place between police personnel and Mr. Mahto. The JLKM leader alleged that he sustained an injury to his chest while being stopped and jostled by the police. Mr. Mahto also alleged that the police assaulted and beat up his associates who came to rescue him.

He also shared the footage of the altercation on his official social media account.

“For 14 days, I have been on a hunger strike, and today the police tried to push and forcefully stop me along with my companions. The police also assaulted my people who were with me,” Mr. Mahto wrote on X.

After the alleged assault, Mr. Mahto, along with his people, sat down on dharna right outside his room.

“Until I am allowed to leave from here, I will keep sitting right here. I will not even get my treatment done, and I will stay here to raise my concern. My fight is for the rights of the people and for justice. They (Police) cannot silence my voice by stopping me,” Mr. Mahto said.

Sonia tried to stop *Vande Mataram*, claims BJP; Congress rejects charge

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

Subsequently, Ms. Gandhi and the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi were seen having an animated discussion with Seva Dal chief B.V. Srinivas, and his predecessor Lalji Desai.



Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge alongside Sonia Gandhi, Rahul Gandhi and Ajay Maken at AICC headquarters in New Delhi on Saturday. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

“Today, on Independence Day, when *Vande Mataram* was sung in its entirety in keeping with the sentiments of millions of Indians, the sight of Congress’s supreme leader Sonia Gandhi, super president Rahul Gandhi, and

“We condemn this conduct of the Congress party’s top leadership and expect the Congress party to

Defending the party's position, Congress's communications chief Jairam Ramesh said Ms. Gandhi had been asking for a chair for Mr. Kharge. "As the Congress president was standing for a long time, Sonia ji was asking for a chair for him," Mr. Ramesh claimed. "But today, at Indira Bhawan, the full session [of the *Vande Mata*

The controversy assumes significance against the backdrop of guidelines issued by the Union Home Ministry in February, and reiterated in July, on the observance of the National Song, and the subsequent passage of the Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Act, 2026.

'Dimagi Naxals' remark by Prime Minister draws criticism from Opposition

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Naxals) in his address, alleging that it was an attempt to stigmatise dissent and intimidate those questioning the government. They criticised his appeal for political parties to help implement 33% reservation for women in legisla-

Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh said Mr. Modi had first described his opponents as “urban Naxals” and now calling them “*dimagdi* Naxals”, terming it a “sure sign of his desperation”. He called the Prime Minis-

CPI general secretary D. Raja said Mr. Modi had chosen to target dissenters even on Independence Day. "This is nothing but an attempt to stigmatise dissent and intimidate those who question the government," he said, asking the Prime Minister to answer questions from students and youth on education and employment.

On the draw



Fadnavis backs PM's 'intellectual Naxals' remark

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Addressing the nation on the 80th Independence Day, Mr. Modi said “intellectual Naxals” (*dimaghi Naxals*) have become part of the system and continue to pose a threat to society. He urged citizens to “iden-

“Unfortunately, we saw one such example even at today’s Congress programme. The decision to play the complete *Vande Mataram* on August 15 was taken within the constitutional powers of the country. If reports that Sonia Gandhi was unhappy because the full *Vande Mataram* was played are true, then what else can this be but ‘*dimag*’ Naxalism among people whose



Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis pays floral tributes to Krantijyoti Savitribai Phule in Mumbai on Saturday. ANI

Women's reservation

Parliament, Mr. Fadnavis said parties opposing the proposal should understand the constitutional conditions attached to the 2023 legislation.

“Those who are selec-

U.P. CM rolls out integrated policy for State's youth

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

“The strength of Uttar Pradesh lies in the talent of its youth. The government has taken strict action against the cheating mafia and recruitment mafia, and the state’s demographic dividend is being transformed into a ‘development engine,” he said.

Return whatever was taken away from J&K, says Omar Abdullah

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

He also said, "Federalism suffers when central agencies interfere in matters falling within the States' domain or when powers vested with States are eroded or exercised by central agencies."

Referring to examina-



J&K CM Omar Abdullah at a parade during the Independence Day celebration at Bakshi Stadium in Srinagar. IMRAN NISSAR

'A matter of regret'
He also referred to the situation in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK), where scores of protesters died in firing by security forces over the past two months.

"The condition of people in that part of Jammu

Meanwhile, Mr. Abdullah also paid tribute to National Conference (NC) founder Sheikh Mohammad Abdullah and termed him the “greatest leader” and the “most courageous person” of J&K. “Any Independence Day reflection in J&K would remain incomplete without remembering his contribution,” he added. He also remembered NC leader Master

dignity of citizens. In a post on X, the party wrote, "Independence is not merely the freedom to celebrate a day; it is the freedom to speak, to dissent, to dream and to live with dignity. On this Independence Day, let us reclaim the promise of our Constitution and make freedom meaningful for every Indian. Happy Independence Day."

Global partners greet India, reaffirm bilateral relations

Press Trust of India
KATHMANDU/SINGAPORE

The Russian President said Russia-India relations are developing successfully in the spirit of a "particu-

Israeli President Isaac Herzog also wished India's top leadership and the "wonderful people" of the country on Independence Day. "May we continue to strengthen the beautiful friendship between Israel and India," he said in a social media post.

Shah: PM's I-Day speech a Viksit Bharat milestone

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

He said the Prime Minister highlighted the unprecedented progress made over the last 12 years in sectors such as semiconductors, critical minerals, energy, and railway transport. He presented the mantra of *Saptadhara* – seven pillars of strength – to propel the country to new heights, Mr. Shah said.

The Prime Minister set ambitious targets, such as achieving 100 gigawatts of nuclear power capacity and establishing eight new semiconductor units by 2047, he said.

M CH-CHE

Govt. reduces export levy on petrol to nil; diesel, ATF cut

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

In their latest fortnightly review, the Union government cut the export duty on petrol to nil while reducing the levy on export of diesel and aviation turbine fuel (ATF) to ₹24 and ₹19.5 for every litre respectively.

There is no change in excise duty rates for petrol and diesel for domestic retail consumption.

Since the peak of the conflict in West Asia earlier this year, the Union government has been fortnightly reviewing export levies since March 27 to ensure domestic availability of the fuel by disincentivising exports.

In the previous fortnightly review, the Union government had increased the export levy on petrol to ₹3.5 per litre, diesel to ₹25.5 per litre and that on ATF to ₹22 per litre.

Nyka Steel: NCLAT upholds order

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) upheld an order passed by the NCLT, directing insolvency proceedings against personal guarantor of Nyka Steel. It involves UCO Bank's IBC plea on Asif Ahmed Siddique.

As Govt. mulls MDR on UPI, data shows cash usage quickening

An analysis by *The Hindu* shows that the growth in the value of UPI transactions has been consistently slowing since 2021-22, although the current rate of growth is still higher than that of cash with the public

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

At a time when the government is proposing to allow the levy of a charge on UPI transactions, an analysis shows that the growth in the value of UPI transactions has been slowing for the last five years, while the growth of cash with the public has been quickening over this period.

While slowing, the growth of UPI transactions remains faster than the growth of cash with the public, this margin is shrinking. Experts say this is both a sign of higher economic activity and also higher price levels than are being reflected in the official inflation data

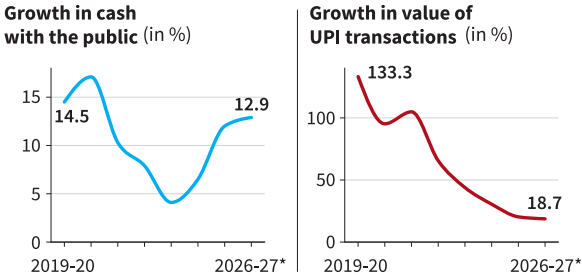
UPI and RuPay debit card transactions are currently free, like cash transactions. However, the government passed the Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026 in the recently-concluded Monsoon session of Parliament which enables it to allow a Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) charge to be levied on these electronic transactions.

Cash is back

An analysis by *The Hindu* of data from the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) shows that the growth rate of cash with the public reached a recent high of about 17% in the COVID-19 pandemic year of 2020-21.

Cashing in

Even as the growth rate of UPI transactions has continued to fall, the growth of cash with the public has continued to accelerate



Source: RBI & NPCI | *Note: Growth in cash with the public for 2026-27 is up to July 31, 2026 compared with the same period of the previous year. Growth in UPI transactions for 2026-27 is up to August 9, 2026 compared with the same period of the previous year.

Opposition says the merchants who do have to pay the levy would pass on higher cost to customers

Thereafter, the growth of cash with the public fell consistently until 2023-24, where it hit about 4%.

Cash with the public is the total cash in circulation minus what is sitting in banks.

Since then, the growth of cash with the public has been quickening. That is, this growth rate increased to 6.5% in 2024-25 and further to 12% in 2025-26.

In 2026-27, cash with the public, at ₹41.8 lakh crore as of July 31, 2026, was almost 13% higher than in the same period of the previous year.

Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman and the Payments Corporation of India have given assurances that the general public would not have to pay the MDR charge on UPI transactions and that it would only be levied on certain high value transactions.

However, the Opposition has said that the merchants who do have to pay this charge would pass on that higher cost to their customers in the form of higher prices and that this could push people back to using cash.

UPI slowing but high

UPI transactions, on the other hand, have seen the growth slowing over the last few years, according to the data with the National Payments Corporation of

India (NPCI).

The value of UPI transactions conducted in the country increased by 133% in 2019-20, which then slowed to a relatively robust 95% in 2020-21 as the economy locked down.

It then quickened again to 105% in 2021-22 as the economy opened up and the pent-up demand combined with health fears over handling cash to push up UPI usage.

Since then, however, the growth in the value of transactions done on the UPI platform has consistently been slowing, with growth hitting 20.3% in 2025-26.

In 2026-27, this has further slowed to 18.7% as of August 2026, compared with the April-August period of last year.

However, this 18.7% growth in UPI transactions is still higher than the 13% growth in cash with the public in the same period.

Inflation understated?

According to Pronab Sen, former Chief Statistician of the Government of India and former Chairman of the Standing Committee on Statistics, the fact that both cash and UPI transactions are growing should be manifesting in the form of higher inflation rates than what the official numbers are currently showing.

“This would imply that we are under-counting in-

flation, because that's where this should show up,” Mr. Sen told *The Hindu*. “If there is more money being transacted, both digitally and in cash, then that should show up in inflation. The first effect would be there.

“A lot of this could be explained if the official data showed prices were rising faster than they are,” he added.

The latest official retail inflation data for July 2026 stood at 4.45%, slightly higher than in June, while the wholesale data showed inflation had slowed marginally to 9.8% in July from 9.9% in June.

Vibrant economy

D.K. Srivastava, chief policy advisor at EY India, says that simultaneous cash and UPI growth is a sign of a vibrant economy.

“The first reason is increasing economic activity in general,” Mr. Srivastava said. “That is to say, high growth rates. We have been maintaining a real growth rate in excess of 7% in the post-COVID years. That is the main reason why both cash transactions and digital transactions have increased.”

Mr. Sen, however, warned that an increase in the number of cash transactions could also point towards distress in the economy brought upon by high unemployment, especially among the youth.

‘Top 5 big family businesses hold over 60% income’

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

The top five big family businesses held over 60% of income share in corporate India in the past two decades even as liberalisation made markets more competitive, according to a study appearing in World Bank Economic Review.

The study titled “Business Groups, Concentration and Market Power in India” published in the World Bank Economic Review authored by Simon Commander, visiting professor at IE Business School, Madrid, Spain among other researchers from different universities, found that Reliance, Adani, Birla, Om Prakash Jindal and Tata Groups put together controlled over 60% of business revenue between 2001 and 2020.

Barring Birla Group, whose share in total gross revenue reduced steadily during the study period, the shares of other family businesses increased. Reliance and Adani Groups have consistently constituted at least 20% share in total income. The shares of Om Prakash Jindal and Tata Groups increased steadily but stayed at less than 10% of income shares.

Concentration fell

The study acknowledges that the concentration in the market has reduced and as a result competitiveness has increased after liberalisation. This however has not prevented the



Top 25 family business groups constitute over 15% of the GDP.

large family business groups from dominating the market. The top 25 family business groups constitute more than 15% of the Gross Domestic Product-the value of goods and services sold in 2020, the study observed.

“The paper finds that market concentration has indeed been declining during that period, mainly due to policy-induced shrinkage of the public sector. Concentration has also been falling for the private sector and for the FBGs. Thus, at the NIC-3 level, the proportion of industries with low concentration has risen considerably over the period,” the authors observed. The largest five firms controlled more than half of the revenue in around 74% of NIC-3 industries, the study found.

NIC 3 refers to a Statistics Ministry classification of industries by specific sub sectors.

At the same time, family business groups have also diversified across different sectors, the study found.



Little hope: Prolonged uncertainty caused considerable anxiety, frustration and emotional distress, says Saluja. REUTERS

Wipro's onboarding delay: IT rights body writes to Minister

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Nascent Information Technology Employees Senate (NITES), a Mumbai-based organisation working for the rights of IT employees, has sent a written complaint to Union Labour Minister Mansukh Mandaviya on the “prolonged and unexplained delay” in onboarding more than 200 students and young engineers selected by Wipro Ltd. under its Elite Hiring 2025 process.

Harpreet Singh Saluja, president of NITES and an advocate of the Bombay High Court, stated in the letter that the affected students and young engineers participated in Wipro's campus recruitment process on February 1, 2025, and cleared subsequent rounds in the same month.

Following interviews, they received offer letters on July 22, 2025, and ‘Letters of Intent’ in August 2025. “In December 2025, they reconfirmed interest through Wipro's official survey,” Mr. Saluja said, adding despite completing every requirement communicated by Wipro, these students and young engineers did not receive defi-

nite onboarding or joining date.

Wipro's response

A Wipro spokesperson told *The Hindu* Wipro remained committed to onboarding the freshers, in line with its business requirements.

“We will continue to keep candidates informed on further updates,” the spokesperson added.

Mr. Saluja said, “The consequences are serious. These are young people at the beginning of professional careers who planned careers and financial commitments around the employment offered by Wipro. Many state that they declined or did not pursue other employment opportunities while awaiting onboarding.

“They and families have consequently faced continuing financial uncertainty and burdens relating to education, accommodation, daily expenses and family responsibilities. Prolonged uncertainty caused considerable anxiety, frustration and emotional distress.”

Mr. Saluja asked the Minister to initiate action at the earliest.

(Inputs from Mini Tejaswi)

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER PWD DN MANDALGARH
Email.ID eemandalgarh.pwd@rajasthan.gov.in
Court Road Mandalgarh Distt Bhilwara
NIB CODE – PWD2627A2122
Short Term Notice Inviting Bid- 10/2026-27
Bids for Contract for Construction/Rehabilitation of Non Panchable/Missing Link Road Under Budget Announcement FY 2026-27 invited from interested bidders upto 20.08.2026 other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal (http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in http://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in) of the state the approximate value of the procurement is Rs. 1275.57 Lakh.
NIB CODE – PWD2627A2122
UBN No PWD2627WSOB09517, PWD2627WSOB9518 PWD2627WSOB9520 PWD2627WSOB9521 PWD2627WSOB9522 PWD2627WSOB9523
(S.L.Bairwa)
Executive Engineer
PWD Dn Mandalgarh
DIRPC/14563/2026 Email.ID semandalgarh.pwd@rajasthan.gov.in

कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, सार्वजनिक निर्माण विभाग, ग्रामीण वृत्त जोधपुर
क्रमांक: 1394 दिनांक: 07.08.2026
अल्पकालीन निविदा सूचना संख्या : 05 वर्ष 2026-27
NIB No. PWD2627A2075
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Bids For Construction of Various Class Room & Roads Under DMFT Scheme YEAR 2026-27 Procurement are invited from interested bidders upto 6.00 PM of 19.08.2026 Other particulars of the id may be visited on the procurement portal (http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in, http://sppp.raj.nic.in) of the state website. The approximate value of the procurement is Rs. 396.51 Laes
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‘Despite reputation, India’s per-unit space launch cost highest’

The dependence matters because launch cost, the authors argue, is becoming a geopolitical issue: “SpaceX ... was responsible for 75% of global payload to orbit in 2025 ... going forward, it is not implausible that a U.S. administration might decide to weaponise this dependency or use it as a bargaining chip to coerce other nations.”

Replacing a functional fossil-fuel vehicle with an EV is almost always better for the climate even if the former car is new, an analysis of lifecycle emissions has found. While manufacturing a new EV creates a carbon debt, it is usually paid back as lower emissions (while driving) within three years. Over time, retiring a gas car early and switching to an EV can reduce total carbon emissions by roughly 44% across cars, SUVs, and trucks.

FAQ

What does Anthropic stand to gain and risk with its IPO?

What is Anthropic planning? Who does it compete with? What threat do Chinese and open source models pose? How could recursive learning decide the race?

Aroon Deep

The story so far: Anthropic is reportedly planning a \$2 trillion initial public offering (IPO) by September, according to a *Financial Times* report. Since the AI product Claude already rakes in billions of dollars, this would likely be a blockbuster IPO were it to be held today. Anthropic’s product is incredibly popular, with software engineers handing off increasingly large amounts of advanced coding work to agents built with the AI tool.

Who does Anthropic compete with? Along with Claude, ChatGPT and Codex continue to compete neck and neck with Anthropic’s tools. For coding-focused tasks and processes where AI tool use is needed, firms such as Cursor, recently acquired by SpaceX, could also pose a threat. And then there is the rapidly growing open source model ecosystem, where AI tools that can run on sufficiently advanced PCs are able to manage increasingly complex tasks just fine locally.

What threat do Chinese and open source models pose?

As corporates move through their experimentation and tighter budgets, firms extracting the highest reasoning from their models will attract the most investor interest

Anthropic faces significant risks in terms of the competition it faces both from other companies and countries. Fuelled by several years of research and capacity-building pushes, Chinese firms are gaining

ground on AI, with open source models like Alibaba’s Qwen shocking users with low hardware requirements and competitive performance.

So-called open source “harnesses,” which provide an interface for running the AI, have also emerged, like Bionic. These harnesses mimic the approachable interfaces of ChatGPT and Claude, even though they are – like all LLMs – just next-word prediction tools. If these tools get sufficiently advanced, the potential disruptions to subscription- and usage-based tools like Claude could be significant.

Does Anthropic’s size protect it? This is no reason to write off a firm as large as Anthropic. While size is no guarantee of success in entering the AI space – Microsoft, for instance, has had more luck in being an infrastructure platform for AI rather than an “inference” (AI query-response) provider on its own merit – there is a significant advantage for a company in having its AI tools being used widely.

Early stumbles by Google (whose Gemini model and other AI tools have caught up in the last few months) show that resources and AI lab size are no guarantee of dominance, especially when there is months of financing and reputational advantages to moving early.

How could continual learning decide the race?

The AI blogger Dwarkesh Patel said earlier this month that so-called continual learning, where an AI tool’s real world use is fed back into its training, could make a major difference in how good it is. “Right now, there are less than five prominent AI minds, and they are all quite similar to each other on account of being trained on roughly the same data,” Patel says. “But if AIs are learning from experience, and that experience is different between different AIs, we could see actually different AIs come out the other end.”

He adds, “When deployment becomes part of training, the returns to being ahead will accelerate. If you have the best model, and more people use your AI for more complicated and useful work, and give it lots of feedback that it can integrate beyond the session window, then your model will become even smarter.”

What does RL mean for the IPO? Since Claude’s models are not open source, those real world recursive learning gains would be significant, and give Anthropic pricing power. Then again, that is assuming that it leverages its current dominance to improve future models at a breathless pace, and assuming that open models and competitors don’t collectively erode its ability to self-improve in the coming months. A major focus of all the AI labs going forward is likely to be token cost, which is how much they charge enterprises for each unit of reasoning. As corporates move through their experimentation and controlling costs more (as they did with so-called finops for the cloud computing era), firms that are able to get the most reasoning out of their models, such as by leveraging more efficiency out of their tokens, will see the most investor interest.

Why has the Centre opposed creamy layer for SC/STs?

What did the Centre argue in the Supreme Court? What is the context for its position? What is sub-categorisation and what is the creamy layer concept? What is the Centre’s position on sub-categorisation? What could happen next in the Supreme Court?

Abhinav Lakshman

The story so far: Opposing a batch of petitions seeking a “creamy layer” exclusion from the reserved categories of Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (like that for Other Backward Classes), the Union government recently reiterated in the Supreme Court of India that this concept of carving out exclusions within reserved categories was not applicable to the SC and ST classifications.

What brought this about? The current batch of petitions pending before the Supreme Court largely came through after a significant judgment of the top court in August 2024 (*Davinder Singh*), which recognised the “heterogeneity” of communities classified as SC and ST and the graded backwardness among the communities already in these constitutional lists. While doing so, a seven-judge Bench of the Court, headed by then Chief Justice of India, D.Y. Chandrachud, granted sanction to State governments to sub-categorise within the existing lists of SCs and STs to ensure that the benefits of reservations reach communities that have been routinely crowded out by relatively less backward communities within their respective lists.

However, in this judgment, Justice (Retd.) B.R. Gavai, in the opinion he had authored, noted that the problem of graded inequality and continued crowding out of certain SC/ST communities from benefits like reservations in public education and employment required that the government seriously start considering introducing a concept of “creamy layer” exclusions within these lists as well, as introduced for the OBCs in the landmark *Indra Sawhney* judgement (1992).

This particular observation had ignited protests from several SC and ST associations across the country, and the Union government and the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) were

Its opposition rests on the thinking that this would require exclusion of either certain communities or individuals from the benefit of reservation altogether – a power that the Social Justice Ministry has argued rests solely with Parliament

quick to take a strong position against the introduction of a creamy layer concept for SC and ST quotas. But this opened the door for petitions seeking orders that the Union government introduce this concept for SC/ST quotas as well, which prompted the Supreme Court to issue a notice to the Centre earlier this year. The Court also asked the Union government for a report on the action taken since the 2024 *Davinder Singh* judgment, intertwining sub-categorisation and creamy layer exclusion once again.

What is the context for this position? The most recent reiteration of the Union government in the Supreme Court against introducing the creamy layer exclusion for SC/ST quotas comes at a time when a significant section of students in the country (largely from the General Category) – traditionally been sympathetic to the ruling BJP establishment – have been participating in the Reservation Hatao Andolan (RHA). This a movement came into being through an Instagram page, soon after the countrywide student movement ignited by the Cockroach Janta Party led to the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over the issue of the NEET paper leak. The RHA page on Instagram has garnered over 5 million followers and is being given direction by key actors of the anti-reservation movement such as Ajeet Bharti, Anuradha Twari, and Neha Das. All three have been consistently vocal for the rights of General Category students and job seekers and had also helped mobilise and amplify the protests against the UGC’s 2026 social equity rules earlier this year over alleged discrimination against General Category students. One of the principal demands of the RHA is to abolish all socio-economic caste reservation categories and only retain “income-based reservation”.

What does graded inequality, sub-categorisation and creamy layer stand for?

The idea of sub-categorisation is to divide an existing quantum of reservation for a single category to ensure access for unequal groupings within that category. The idea of a “creamy layer” exclusion is meant to identify individuals within a particular categorisation who may have escaped certain effects of discrimination or backwardness that their communities at large may still be facing, and then exclude them from availing themselves of reservation altogether. Both tools are aimed at restricting the crowding out of relatively more backward communities or individuals within a given category by relatively forward communities or individuals in that category.

Where does creamy layer apply and where is sub-categorisation being done? While the government has maintained that the

concept of creamy layer exclusions applied to OBC communities only, we could argue that the Economically Weaker Sections (EWS) reservation also embodies a similar idea. One criterion for availing this quota is that a person must not be eligible for any benefits meant for SCs, STs, or OBCs and must also belong to a family below a prescribed income and asset threshold. In this sense, the EWS framework also excludes those deemed economically better off, much like the creamy layer exclusion for OBCs, although the criteria and method of calculating income and assets are different.

The tool of sub-categorisation, however, has been more widely wielded – for SCs, STs, and OBCs – but more by State governments than by the Central government. The only arguable example of the Centre using sub-categorisation nationally has been within the ST category for admissions to Eklavya Model Residential Schools, where the ST quota is further divided to ensure minimum representation for Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups.

What is the Centre’s position and rationale? Even though the Union government is yet to make public its vision for using the sub-categorisation tool nationally for SC, ST, and OBC categories, its opposition to the introduction of the creamy layer concept in SC/ST quotas rests on the thinking that this would require exclusion of either certain communities or individuals from the benefit of reservation altogether – a power that the Social Justice Ministry has argued rests solely with Parliament. Further, it has argued that judicial precedent so far has never called for or suggested creamy layer exclusion for SC/ST.

Though it has taken this position in the ongoing cases before the top court, the Centre has notably left a potential roadmap for what it would take for it to consider such a move. It has said that such modifications to the reservation policy “should be preceded by a holistic review and thorough empirical study, including socio-economic data of reserved category beneficiaries” but stressed that it was not within the domain of the judiciary to direct it.

While the government has been clear about the classifications to which creamy layer exclusions would apply, it has been less emphatic about the scope of sub-categorisation. In its first term, the Modi government indicated that it was keen on sub-categorising OBCs nationally. The National Commission for Backward Classes recommended it in 2015, and the Centre formed the Justice (Retd.) G. Rohini Commission for this task in 2017. The report was submitted three ago years, but has not seen the light of day.

Similarly, when the issue of sub-categorisation of SCs was gaining prominence ahead of the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, both in the Supreme Court and in States such as Telangana and Andhra Pradesh, the Union government constituted an internal committee headed by the Cabinet Secretary to examine how the grievances of the Madigas could be addressed. But since the *Davinder Singh* judgment paved the way for sub-categorisation in principle, the Centre has remained silent on the issue.



Demonstrators take part in a Reservation Hatao Andolan rally in Nagpur, Maharashtra. PTI

Why has Bashar al-Assad been sentenced to death?

What are the charges against the former Syrian President, his brother, cousin, and others? Where are they right now? Why will it be difficult for the Shaara government to carry out the sentence? Why has Amnesty International expressed concerns over the judicial proceedings?

Vighnesh P. Venkitesh

The story so far: On August 11, the Fourth Criminal Court in Damascus sentenced Bashar al-Assad, who ruled Syria for more than two decades before being forced to flee amid a civil war in 2024, to death. Along with him, his brother Maher al-Assad, who commanded the notorious Fourth Division of the Army and was considered the regime’s top security official, cousin Atef Najib, and six others have also been sentenced.

While Najib is currently being in held in Syria and was present for the trials and ruling, the other eight were sentenced in absentia. The Assad brothers are currently under Russian asylum. The extradition of those sentenced in absentia, and the enforcement of their sentences, might be an arduous task for the present government under Ahmad al-Shaara, the former al-Qaeda operative with links to the Islamic State who, as Abu Muhammad al-Jolani, led the swift movement against the Assad regime in 2024 before taking over. However, the

Witnesses, underage during the Daraa uprising, testified in court about undergoing torture like beatings, electric shocks, suspension, and nail removal

sentencing could serve as a tool for political transition in the country.

What are the charges against Bashar al-Assad and others?

The judicial proceedings against the Assad brothers and their loyalists were the results of the efforts by the National Commission for Transitional Justice (NCTJ) set up by Mr. Shaara in May 2025 to investigate serious human right abuses during the “previous regime” and hold those responsible to account.

The Fourth Criminal Court in Damascus, presided over by Judge Fakhr al-Din al-Aryan, began trial of the ousted leader and others in April this year and convicted him, his brother, cousin, and the six others of murder, torture, unlawful deprivation of liberty, crimes against humanity, and war crimes.

The charges go back to the crackdown on the Daraa uprising in 2011. Protests were sparked by the detention and alleged torture of teenagers who drew anti-Assad graffiti on walls in Daraa. Demonstrations against this detention were met with a crackdown, which ignited nationwide movements and later led to instability in Syria. This opened the avenue for a civil war.

Witnesses, who were minors at the time of the uprising, recalled in court undergoing severe torture including beating, electric shocks, suspension, and nail removal. Some said Najib, who was then the head of political security in Daraa, personally interrogated them. The court held the ousted leader Assad responsible for a “joint criminal project”, saying that as President throughout the period covered by the case, including the years-long civil war that followed shortly after the uprising, he had power over state institutions. The former President was convicted for intentional murder of multiple people, intentional killing of children under 15, intentional killing accompanied by torture and brutality, and incitement to intentional murder



People celebrate after Atef Najib, a cousin of Bashar al-Assad, was sentenced to death for overseeing a crackdown in Daraa in 2011, in Damascus. AP

on multiple occasions.

How is the administration planning to implement the sentence?

The two Assad brothers live in Russia. The country previously denied extradition requests by the Shaara administration – it was a strong ally of Syria’s during the previous regime and helped it during the civil war against the U.S.-backed Kurdish group, Syrian Democratic Forces, and other militias. This is why the court and the administration will find it hard to carry out the sentence. However, the court has ordered arrest warrants against the “fugitives”, directing authorities to take necessary measures for their international prosecution. Following this, Syria’s Deputy Justice Minister Mustafa al-Qassem on August 12 announced the formation of a committee to seek the extradition of those convicted, saying that the panel would coordinate with Interpol to secure their handover.

What are the concerns against in-absentia trials?

Amnesty International has expressed concerns over the judicial proceedings, stressing shortly after the verdict was issued that trials and death sentences in absentia are incompatible with international standards of fair-trial guarantees. The sentencing of the Assad brothers and others followed the recent precedent set by Bangladesh, where ousted Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina was similarly sentenced to death in absentia for crimes against humanity, by the country’s International Crimes Tribunal in November last year.

Reacting to the proceedings in Syria, Amnesty noted that prosecuting those responsible for grave violations of human rights was key to achieving justice, but said that trials in absentia should be abolished if the Sharaa government wanted to “truly turn the page on the horrors of the past”. However, Syria’s Justice Ministry pushed back against the criticism, saying its statement “does not accurately reflect the nature of the judicial procedures followed in these cases or the safeguards guaranteed to litigants under Syrian law”.

PROFILES

India’s lunar future

Moon Base

NASA has invited ISRO to participate in its latest lunar programme, which seeks to build a human outpost near the Moon’s south pole, where sunlight is available for longer periods and permanently shadowed craters contain significant deposits of water ice

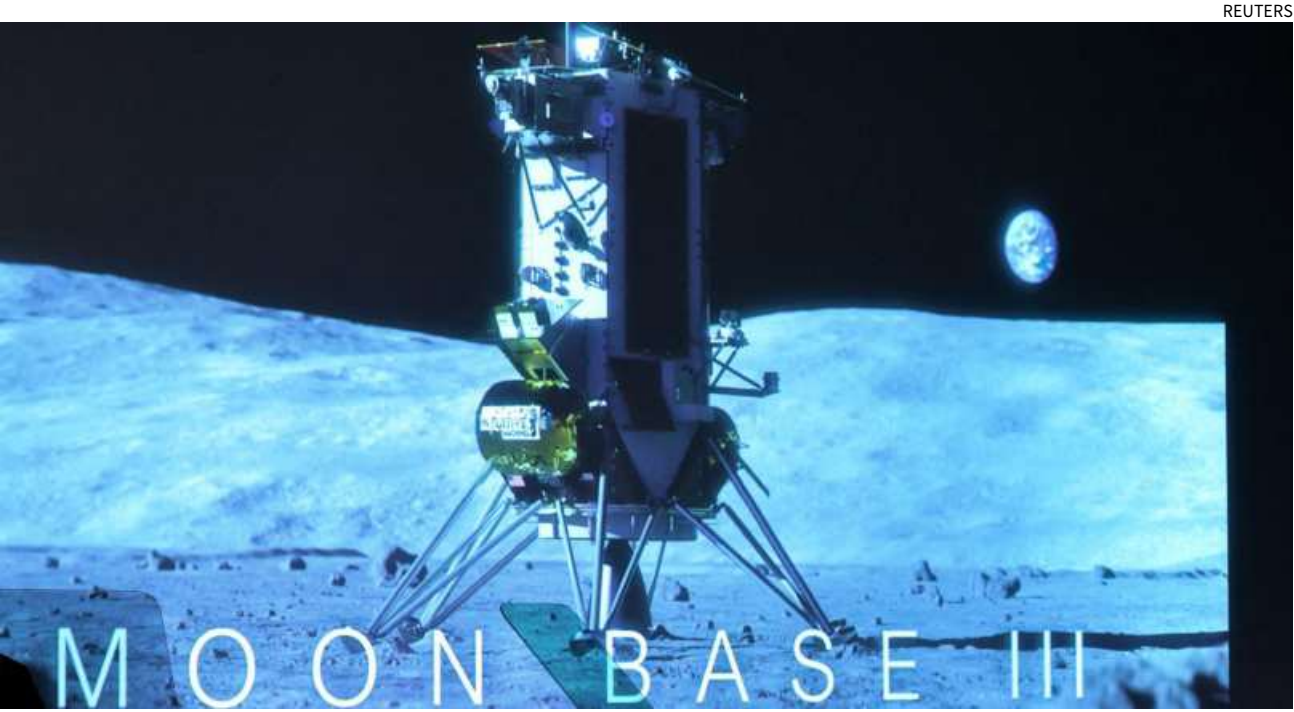
Vasudevan Mukunth

“The past is a foreign country; they do things differently there,” the English novelist L.P. Hartley wrote famously in his 1953 novel *The Go-Between*. In a peculiar twist, the same cannot be said of the Moon. It is not a foreign country, or even a foreign world: the U.S.’s manoeuvring to beat China to the satellite has increasingly meant the moon is an extension of the Earth’s geopolitics and political culture.

At the ninth India-U.S. Civil Space Joint Working Group meeting at Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) headquarters last week, NASA invited the organisation to participate in its ‘Moon Base’ programme, ostensibly as part of the two countries’ Artemis Accords partnership. According to NASA, the facility will be built piece by piece near the Moon’s south pole, where sunlight is available for longer durations and where permanently shadowed craters hold significant water-ice deposits. The target is for it to be humankind’s first outpost on a new celestial body, taking shape around 2030.

NASA is leaning heavily on private industry for this, having already awarded contracts to Astrolab (worth \$219 million) and Lunar Outpost (\$220 million) for lunar terrain vehicles, Blue Origin (\$188 million) for delivery task orders, and Astrobotic, Firefly Aerospace, and Intuitive Machines (\$600 million) for four robotic missions to the Moon to deliver equipment. Intuitive is also developing a relay satellite under a separate contract.

Further, as part of NASA chief Jared Isaacman’s overhaul of the Artemis programme earlier this year, in no small part responding to the Trump administration’s December 2025 space policy calling for securing U.S. interests in cislunar space, the profiles of the Artemis III and IV Missions changed. Now, Mission III will be a crewed test flight in Earth orbit in 2027 and Mission IV will attempt the first



REUTERS

lunar landing under the programme in 2028. Taken together, the ‘Moon Base’ is effectively the next phase of the new Artemis programme, tasked with keeping – intermittently at first, and eventually continuously – Artemis astronauts on the Moon.

Deepening partnership

Since India signed the Artemis Accords in 2023, NASA and ISRO have engaged regularly across several areas. NASA has trained India’s astronaut candidates for the ‘Gaganyaan’ human spaceflight mission. In 2025, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and U.S. President Donald Trump jointly announced a broader strategic technologies framework, including spaceflight.

ISRO also launched the NASA-ISRO Synthetic Aperture Radar, a major scientific mission that has been a decade in the making. NASA instruments are slated to fly on forthcoming Chandrayaan missions just as they did on the first three.

While it seems almost facile to suggest the U.S. also engage with China considering the latter’s formidable

spaceflight capabilities – many industry experts agree the age of U.S. dominance in spaceflight is in its twilight years – the two countries’ actions mean that the lines they have drawn on the Earth are set to be extended to the Moon, and that will pose new challenges for India.

In 2021, China and Russia announced plans to cooperate on an ‘International Lunar Research Station’ (ILRS), which China described as a long-term lunar science and technology facility, also to be built near the south pole and with a targeted deadline of 2035. Like the Artemis Accords, the ILRS is an international effort, currently involving 17 countries and organisations and more than 50 research institutions worldwide.

Earlier this year, when NASA solicited proposals for payloads to send to the Moon, it said it welcomed foreign entities “except those with bilateral ties to China”. NASA’s FY2027 budget request has also described the ‘Moon Base’ as a means to establish U.S. “superiority on the Moon” and to preserve U.S. leadership in space –

language with more strategic overtones relative to the agency’s pre-Trump rhetoric.

Given how much of U.S. policy is shaped by out-competing China, India’s gains or losses will not be restricted to its space programme either. For instance, ISRO’s engagement with NASA has arguably become more politicised thanks to NASA’s own politicisation by virtue of having to respond to China’s ILRS plans. Contrary to the focus areas of these bodies through much of their histories, future discussions would be poorly served by treating their engagement on the Moon as purely exploratory.

For example, the Artemis Accords do not say a signatory cannot cooperate with non-signatory countries. (In June, ISRO also hosted the BRICS Heads of Space Agencies meeting in Bengaluru with China among the participants). However, the Artemis programme itself is increasingly concerned with infrastructure, and building one’s components, equipment, tools, etc. to be interoperable with that

infrastructure will thus extend geopolitical alignments on the Earth to the Moon.

Suppose China invites India to join the ILRS in 2035. (In fact, the Moon could become one of the few domains in which India and China may have a practical incentive to cooperate on the Moon even while competing on the Earth, and India should endeavour to preserve rather than foreclose that possibility.) The government can say ‘yes’, but if China uses different communication protocols, data formats or operational procedures, India will face a tough choice: to build a second, expensive set of capabilities with China or to persuade China to change its systems to be interoperable with American designs.

Different ecosystems

That is, the U.S.-China competition means India’s increasing embedding in one technological ecosystem will also increase the cost of engaging with the other in future. At the same time, India will be mistaken to avoid deepening ISRO’s relationship with NASA. The U.S.-led ecosystem is much larger and more technologically diverse than the one led by China. But India may nonetheless have to reconsider its strategic autonomy in the spaceflight domain – particularly if the U.S.-China rivalry changes substantially over the next two or three decades. It should certainly steer clear of any dependencies that could hold back its own space programme because of U.S. objections.

In fact, one useful way to achieve this that also presents yet another opportunity for Indian leadership in space is to push for open international standards that allow nations to retain sovereign control over specific hardware and software components without hampering collaborations in space. Such diplomacy could foster interoperability between the lunar blocs and allow India to retain its strategic autonomy.

If it does not, the Moon may cease to be a foreign world but India may find itself a foreigner there.

THE GIST

NASA is leaning heavily on private industry for Moon Base, having already awarded contracts to Astrolab and Lunar Outpost for lunar terrain vehicles, Blue Origin for delivery task orders, and Astrobotic, Firefly Aerospace, and Intuitive Machines for robotic missions

Further, as part of then-new NASA chief Jared Isaacman’s overhaul of the Artemis programme earlier this year, the profiles of the Artemis III and IV Missions changed

Taken together, the ‘Moon Base’ is effectively the next phase of the new Artemis programme, tasked with keeping – intermittently at first, and eventually continuously – Artemis astronauts on the Moon.

The warrior tradition

Nihang Sikhs

The recent attack on the Akali Dal chief in Maharashtra has brought the community, traditionally regarded as ‘Guru’s army’, back to public attention

Lavpreet Kaur

They are difficult to miss. In electric-blue robes, with towering conical turbans rising above their heads and steel quoits, insignia and rosaries woven into them, Nihang Singhs move through a gathering with swords, spears and other traditional weapons hanging from their bodies. Their appearance is at once religious, martial and theatrical, but for the Nihangs, little of it is ornamental.

The community has returned to public attention after Shiromani Akali Dal president and former Punjab Deputy Chief Minister Sukhbir Singh Badal was attacked with a kirpan at the Mata Sahib Devan Ji Gurdwara in Nanded, Maharashtra, on August 13. The accused, identified as 62-year-old Jaspal Singh, had been serving at the gurdwara for two years and was described as a Nihang.

Nihangs were a conspicuous presence during the farmers’ agitation at Delhi’s Singhu border in 2020-21 and more recently at the student protest at Delhi’s Jantar Mantar in July 2026. Their presence, as much as their distinctive appearance, drew attention.

Their origin is associated with the creation of the Khalsa Panth by the 10th Sikh Guru, Gobind Singh, in 1699. Traditionally regarded as ‘Guru ki fauj’, or the Guru’s army, they re-



PTI

present the armed warrior tradition within Sikhism. The name Nihang is commonly associated with fearlessness and freedom from worldly attachment; another interpretation traces it to the Persian nahan, or crocodile, invoking the creature’s ferocity and toughness.

Historical roots

The tradition took shape in an age when Sikh communities faced repeated military persecution. Nihang warriors became mobile fighting groups, defending Sikh settlements and religious institutions against Mughal forces and, later, Afghan invaders. The martial tradition was subsequently woven into the military structures of the Sikh misls and the forces of Maharaja Ranjit Singh.

With the end of that era of warfare, their battlefield role gradually receded. But the discipline associated with it survived. Today, Nihangs are not a standing army. Their role is largely that of custodians and practitioners of a religious and martial tradition.

There is no single Nihang organisation representing the entire community. Historically divided into two broad dals, Baba Budha Dal and Taruna Dal – associated broadly with older and younger bands, respectively – both have since split into several factions. Researchers estimate there are more than 30 Nihang factions, large and small, in Punjab, making it difficult to arrive at a precise count of Nihangs. Their mobile and decentralised nature means there is no central command or membership registry.

A person wearing blue and carrying a weapon may look like a Nihang, but the traditional order demands considerably more: *bani* (wisdom) and *bana* (attire), spiritual practice and outward discipline, explained Varinder Walia, a former editor with a Punjabi daily and professor at Punjabi University in Patiala. Daily prayers and meditation, knowledge of Sikh scripture, observance of the Khalsa code, Shastar Vidya, the traditional study

and practice of Sikh weaponry, horse-riding, physical endurance and seva form part of the ideal.

Their tradition of movement and collective identity has also brought Nihangs into contemporary public life. Such appearances, historians suggest, need to be understood against the order’s decentralised structure: the presence or actions of one group or individual do not necessarily represent the Nihang community as a whole.

Nanded gives this story another layer. The city on the Godavari is home to Takht Sachkhand Sri Hazur Sahib, one of Sikhism’s five Takhts and the place where Guru Gobind Singh spent the final period of his life. The presence of a Nihang-managed gurdwara in the wider Hazur Sahib religious landscape is part of a much older institutional connection, even as the latest incident there has brought the community under renewed scrutiny.

The challenge in understanding the Nihangs today is to hold these two realities together. They are a living religious order, not a museum piece: their members pray, study scripture, serve food, care for horses and teach martial arts. At the same time, they carry a warrior vocabulary forged in an era when armed defence was central to Sikh survival. The battlefield may have changed, but the identity has endured.

The making of an agitator

Devendra Nath Mahto

The student leader has emerged as the most prominent face of the agitation over alleged irregularities in the conduct of exams in Jharkhand

Suruchi Kumari

On August 10, as thousands of Jharkhand students marched in the capital, Ranchi, to gherao the State Assembly, Devendra Nath Mahto appeared amid the crowd, held aloft by his supporters, with a framed photograph of former Jharkhand Chief Minister Shibu Soren in one hand and the other raised towards the protesters. Flower petals were showered on him as cameras and mobile phones followed his movements.

For a man who has spent a decade organising student protests, the attention is new only in scale. Mr. Mahto, 33, has emerged as the most prominent face of the agitation over alleged irregularities in the 14th Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) preliminary and Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission (JSSC) examinations. He has been on an indefinite hunger strike since August 2, and was hospitalised after the August 10 march.

The current agitation began days after the JPSC results were declared on July 2. A Jharkhand Loktantrik Krantikari Morcha (JLKM) leader, Mr. Mahto held a press conference on July 5, questioning the examination process, and submitted a set of demands to the Governor two days later. On July 8, protesters burnt an effigy

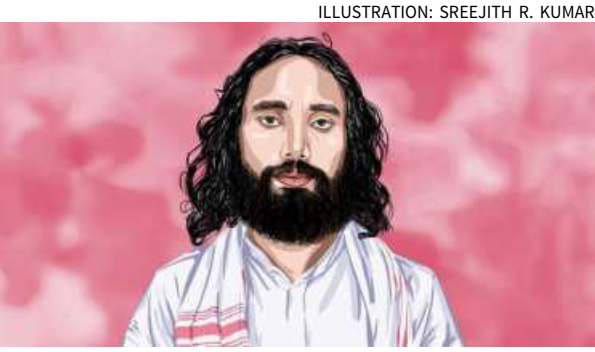


ILLUSTRATION: SREEJITH R. KUMAR

of the JPSC chairman at Albert Ekka Chowk. After a meeting with Chief Minister Hemant Soren on July 20 yielded little, Mr. Mahto called for an indefinite sit-in at Babu Vatika in Morabadi on July 25, later moving to Jaipal Singh Munda Stadium.

The protest has since grown, with gheraos, marches and a continued hunger strike of at least six other students, even after three rounds of talks with the government that yielded in cancellation of JPSC prelims and backlog exams of 2023-25. However, Mr. Mahto says the protest will not be called off until all exams conducted by the TDPL (a private exam conducting agency) are cancelled, including JSSC-CGL, and CBI investigation is recommended.

A stage of students

Owing to his political affiliations, a section of students, days into the protest, set up a different stage to keep their distance from “politics” and insisting that the stage remain independent of political parties.

Mr. Mahto responded by refusing to take the stage again when politics became a point of discussion. His bed was moved below the stage, as he affirmed, “This is the stage of students and their issues, not of any political party.”

There was little in Mr. Mahto’s early life to suggest a political career. Son of Vishambar Mahto, a retired government teacher, he grew up in Rahe village in Ranchi district. He was sent to Bundu, about 10 km from the village, for his matriculation and intermediate education. He later moved to Ranchi. He completed his B.Ed in Hazaribagh and postgraduate studies in Sanskrit and regional languages in Ranchi University till 2022.

“He wanted to be a teacher,” his brother said. “As any village child, he also wanted a simple government job to lead his life. That is why good education was prioritised.”

That changed in college. In 2016, Mr. Mahto began protesting over student scholarships. He subsequently became involved

in demonstrations over recruitment rules, paper leaks and alleged irregularities in JPSC and JSSC exams. According to friends, he has led around a dozen agitations since 2015.

The JLKM, founded by activist-politician Jairam Mahto, became a political vehicle, with Devendra Nath Mahto increasingly involved in its activities. He contested the 2024 Lok Sabha election independently from Ranchi and finished third, securing more than 1.4 lakh votes and then the 2025 Vidhan Sabha election from his home constituency Silli on the JLKM ticket.

The JLKM’s politics also includes the demand to extend Scheduled Tribe reservation to the Kudmi community, to which Mr. Mahto and Jairam Mahto belong. Yet, amid the current agitation, Mr. Mahto insists that his political identity must not eclipse the issue that brought him there.

“This is not my voice. This is the voice of lakhs of aspirants who have been affected, and their mothers who await a better future,” he said. “I knew this movement would grow bigger because this is a student movement.” For now, he says, he will remain on hunger strike. “The government has given us nothing in writing. How can I end my strike until the students are satisfied with the government’s response?” he asked.

TEHRAN
Iran calls for release of pilots held in Qatar during the West Asia war



REUTERS

Iranian authorities on Saturday called for the release of three pilots they say were captured in Qatar during the West Asia war. "Three Iranian pilots were captured alive by Qatari forces after their Su-24 fighter jets crashed," said General Mohammad Bagherzadeh of the Iranian armed forces, *Fars* news agency reported. *AFP*

SANAA
Houthi missiles kill at least four civilians in port city, says Yemen



AFP

Yemen's internationally recognised government said the Houthis fired six ballistic missiles at the Red Sea port of Mocha on Friday, killing four civilians, amid an escalation in hostilities between the Iran-aligned group and its Saudi-backed opponents. The Houthis said they had attacked "Saudi-backed military build-ups". *AP*

SEOUL
South Korea proposes talks with North to formally end Korean War



AFP

South Korean President Lee Jae Myung proposed talks with North Korea to formally end the long-running Korean War, as Pyongyang deepens ties with Russia while asserting its status as a nuclear state. The two Koreas remain technically at war since their 1950-53 conflict ended with an armistice rather than a peace treaty. *AFP*

BANGKOK
Over 300,000 Rohingya refugees verified for repatriation: Myanmar



AP

Myanmar's military-backed government said on Saturday that more than 300,000 Rohingya refugees living in camps in Bangladesh are former residents of western Rakhine state and that it will accept their return once security conditions improve. The statement comes as the Rohingya refugee crisis enters its ninth year. *AP*

Iran fires back at Trump's threat to declare Hormuz a U.S. territory

The waterway is and will remain Iranian, the Islamic republic's officials say in response to Trump's claim; the strait will only be closed and opened under Iran's command, says Gharibabadi; UAE says one of its ADNOC vessels came under attack

Agence France-Presse
TEHRAN

Iran on Saturday fired back at U.S. President Donald Trump's claim that he would soon declare the Strait of Hormuz part of U.S. territory, saying the crucial energy waterway it has blockaded "will remain Iranian".

Mr. Trump has repeatedly said the strait, which Tehran effectively closed at the start of the West Asia war in late February, is under U.S. control – an assertion the Islamic republic denies.

"The Strait of Hormuz has been Iranian, is Iranian, and will remain Iranian," Iranian Deputy Fo-



Critical passage: Vessels are seen in the Strait of Hormuz, off the port city of Bandar Abbas in southern Iran on August 10. *AFP*

reign Minister Kazem Gharibabadi said on X. "This strait will only be closed and opened under Iran's command."

Mr. Trump told a political rally in New York state

on Friday that after the U.S. defeats Iran, "pretty soon I'll be declaring the Hormuz Strait a territory of the United States". "It's true," he added.

An unnamed White

House official later clarified that Mr. Trump was joking, the *Wall Street Journal* reported.

List of conditions

Last week, a top Iranian official laid out a laundry list of conditions for reopening the strait, including an end to the "war and aggression against Iran and its allies in Lebanon, Palestine, Yemen, and Iraq".

Mohammad Bagher Zolqadr also demanded the end of crippling sanctions, the release of frozen assets and compensation for war-time damage.

As diplomacy stalls between the decades-long foes, attacks in the Hormuz strait have continued,

highlighting the continued risks to regional shipping.

United Arab Emirates' state-owned oil giant ADNOC said on Saturday that one of its vessels came under attack the night before.

On Friday, the Gulf nation blamed Iran for other attacks on two vessels linked to ADNOC as they passed through the strait.

Such attacks led to the collapse of an April ceasefire between the United States and Iran.

As Iran throttles traffic in Hormuz, its Houthi allies in Yemen have also declared a parallel maritime blockade on Saudi ports in the Red Sea, the oil-exporting giant's only other maritime route.

Ukraine attacks Russia's Samara industrial site

Associated Press
KYIV

A large-scale Ukrainian attack struck industrial infrastructure in Russia's southwestern Samara region on Saturday, a Russian official said.

Ivan Noskov, head of the region's capital, Samara, said air defence forces had repelled a "massive" missile attack, with "localised damage" to the city's industrial sites. He also said that medical assistance has been provided to those injured in the attack, but did not give further details.

Ukraine has stepped up its long-range aerial attacks on Russian military industries and energy facilities, aiming to cut Moscow's revenue for the war and make Russians feel the consequences of the invasion, now in its fifth year.



A file photo of Vladimir Putin during a visit to the Progress Centre in Samara region in southwestern Russia. *REUTERS*

Writing on social media, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said that Kyiv's forces had carried out a strike against Samara's Progress Centre, which operates under Russian space agency Roscosmos and is involved in producing rocket technology and electronics.

He said that the strike used Ukraine's domestically produced Flamingo mis-

siles to hit the site, which is approximately 900 km from the Ukrainian border. Mr. Zelenskyy also said Russia's Savasleyka air base, some 700 km from the front line, had also been hit.

Russia's Ministry of Defence said that it had shot down 598 Ukrainian drones over 19 Russian regions, as well as the Black and Azov Seas and Crimea.

Israeli air strikes on southern Lebanon kill at least 11 people

Associated Press
BEIRUT

Israeli air strikes on southern Lebanon killed at least 11 people Saturday, in the deadliest attacks since a precarious truce between Israel and Hezbollah went into effect on June 20.

Lebanon's Health Ministry and state news agency said one of the air strikes that targeted a home on the edge of the village of Ansar killed seven people, including three children, and wounded two. The se-

cond, on the village of Deir al-Zahrani, killed four and wounded 17.

Lebanese Prime Minister Nawaf Salam criticised Israel's air strikes, saying they undermine efforts to stabilise the situation.

The Israeli military said that it struck Hezbollah infrastructure in response to an action against Israeli soldiers in the area. It added that it will not allow the Hezbollah to harm Israeli civilians or soldiers "and will continue to operate to remove threats".

Supporters hold street rallies as Taliban regime marks 5 years ruling Afghanistan

Agence France-Presse
KABUL

The Taliban regime celebrated five years of ruling Afghanistan on Saturday, with supporters taking to the streets, while critics decried tightening restrictions in all areas of daily life.

Afghans packed into cars decorated with flags and drove around Kabul on a day that regime spokesperson Zabihullah Mujahid said "will be written in golden lines in the history of Afghanistan".

Hundreds gathered



Afghan youth ride a military vehicle during celebrations to mark the fifth anniversary of Taliban's return to power, on Saturday. *AFP*

around a square beside the former U.S. embassy, while fresh flowers were thrown from military helicopters over a parade of athletes

that featured only men because women are banned from sport in Afghanistan.

Taliban fighters took Kabul unopposed on August

15, 2021, after a lightning offensive that swept across Afghanistan, toppling government forces in the wake of the chaotic withdrawal of U.S.-led troops.

Although Taliban officials have forged ties with multiple countries, including in Europe, their government is still only recognised by Russia.

Some countries have opted to limit their relations with the Taliban authorities until there are changes in Afghanistan, where people are suffering "very real harm" according to the United Nations.

Magnitude 7.7 quake strikes off Indonesia's coast, kills at least 40

Associated Press
MAUMERE

A powerful magnitude 7.7 earthquake struck off the coast of Indonesia early Saturday, killing at least 40 people, collapsing buildings and causing panic in a region prone to deadly quakes. Authorities said dozens of residents were injured.

Authorities issued a tsunami warning and urged coastal residents to move to higher ground, but later lifted the warning when In-

donesia's meteorological agency said monitoring showed no significant sea-level changes that would pose a threat to coastal communities.

East Nusa Tenggara Police Chief Rudi Darmoko said the earthquake caused severe damage and collapsed buildings. He said power outages in cities and villages have complicated rescue efforts.

The toll could rise as landslides triggered by the earthquake buried or cut off many remote villages.

Sport

Petronas TVS Racing's Sarthak snatches a late victory

MOTORSPORTS

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

Sarthak Chavan, 19, snatched a dramatic victory with a last-lap move, leading a 1-2 finish for Petronas TVS Racing team in the Super Sport 301-400cc race to launch his campaign on a bright note in the MRF Indian National Racing Challenge 2W-2026 at the Madras International Circuit here on Saturday.

Ann Jennifer (Motul Sparks Racing) dominated the Super Stock 165cc Intermediate field for a fine win while Allwin Xavier (RACR Castrol Power1) took the honours in the Super Stock 301-400cc Open class.

Both categories were run concurrently.



Fast and furious: Sarthak on the way to winning the Super Sport 301-400cc race. *SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT*

Savion Sabu (Madrabbit Racing) rode a mature race for a superb win in the Pro Stock 200cc class, moving up from sixth while Hari

Haran (RACR Castrol Power1) emerged triumphant in the Stock 165cc (Novice) category. R. Ashwin, a private entrant, topped the

Stock 301-400cc (Novice) race that went down to the wire.

Provisional results (all 6 laps): Super Sport 301-400cc (Race-1): 1. Sarthak Chavan (Petronas TVS Racing) (11min, 01.971secs); 2. Chiranth Vishwanath (Petronas TVS Racing) (11:02.264); 3. Rahil Pillarisetty (RACR Castrol Power1) (11:02.609).

Super Stock 301-400cc Open (Race-1): 1. Allwin Xavier (RACR Castrol Power1) (11:41.198); 2. Seshadri (Motul Gusto Racing) (11:41.824); 3. Kamal Navas (Team Rockers Racing) (11:42.805).

Super Stock 165cc Intermediate (Race-1): 1. Ann Jennifer AS (Motul Sparks Racing) (12:48.559); 2. M. Ajai Xavier (Ipone Yakuza Racing India) (12:51.139); 3. S. Anand Kumar (Ipone Yakuza Racing India) (12:55.914).

Pro-Stock 200cc Open (Race-1): 1. Savion Sabu (Madrabbit Racing) (11:54.910); 2. R.S. Abdul Basim (Chandra LGE

Racing) (11:55.619); 3. Senthil Kumar (Team Rockers Racing) (11:55.666).

Stock 130-16cc (Novice) (Race-1): 1. R. Hari Haran (RACR Castrol Power1) (13:11.711); 2. Yashwant Varma (Motul Sparks Racing) (13:12.286); 3. Faruk Ali Sohtun (Motul Sparks Racing) (13:12.483).

Stock 301-400cc Novice (Race-1): 1. R. Ashwin (Pvt.) (12:19.448); 2. G Balaji (VEEDOL C2 Racing) (12:19.498); 3. Aaron Joseph (RACR Castrol Power1) (12:39.529).

Petronas TVS Racing One-Make Championship: Open (RR 310) (Race-1): 1. Rajender Beedani (11:46.679); 2. R. Hari Haran (11:47.751); 3. Manoj Yesuadiyan (11:53.767).

Women (Apache RTR 200) (Race-1), 5 laps): 1. Poojita Anil Kumar (11:28.499); 2. Drishya Nair (11:35.942); 3. Kinjal Raj (11:42.814).

Rookie (Apache RTR 200) (Race-1): 1. Pothu Vignesh (13:16.496); 2. Rehbar Islam Baktoo (13:17.396); 3. C. Godwin Clarence (13:22.991).

HYDERABAD: The three-year-old colt Bulletproof, who won the Mysore Colts Trial in his last start, should score an encore in the K. Mahipathi Rao Memorial Golconda Juvenile Million, the feature event of Sunday's races.

1. RAZIA SULTANA PLATE (1,600m), (terms) Maiden 3-y-o only (Cat. II), 1-20 p.m.: 1. Master Class (5) Gaurav 56, 2. Smashing Grey (3) Afroz K 56, 3. Twilight King (4) P. Ajeeth K 56, 4. Vidyut-prabhava (1) M.S. Deora 56, 5. Aakarshaka (7) Md. Ismail 54.5, 6. Grit 'N' Grace (8) Shivam 54.5, 7. Ruby Tuesday (6) Arjun 54.5 and 8. Velvera (2) Trevor 54.5.

2. LOYAL MANZAR PLATE (1,600m), 3-y-o and upward, rated 40 to 65 (Cat. II), 2-00: 1. Bholi Punjaban (3) Surya Prakash 60.5, 2. Black Dust (6) P. Sai K 59.5, 3. Wolf Creek (5) Ashad Asfar 58, 4. Authoritarian (2) G. Nareesh 55, 5. Pristine Glory (8) Trevor 52.5, 6. Special Star (7) Ajay K 51.5, 7. Hoping Star (1) Arjun 51 and 8. La Fleur-iere (4) Kuldeep Jr. 50.

3. INDEPENDENCE TROPHY (1,100m), 3-y-o and upward, rated 40 to 65 (Cat. IB), 2-40: 1. Star Of Opera (10) Shivam 61.5, 2. Kalki (12) Kuldeep Jr. 59.5, 3. See The Light (3) Trevor 59, 4. Rival (4) P. Sai K 58, 5. Diligence (5) Kuldeep Sr.

57, 6. N R I Range (9) G. Nareesh 56.5, 7. Sharanga (8) Abhay Singh 56.5, 8. Dashing Charm (1) P. Ajeeth K 55.5, 9. Dontblockmyway (7) Afroz K 55.5, 10. Vital Sign (6) B.R. Kumar 55.5, 11. First Lady (2) B. Nikhil 51.5 and 12. Lazarus (11) Surya Prakash 51.5.

4. HUSBANDRY DEPARTMENT TROPHY (1,400m), 3-y-o and upward, rated 20 to 45 (Cat. III) (No Whips), 3-20: 1. Knotty Senorita (1) Md. Ekram 60.5, 2. Suryavanshi (9) Kuldeep Jr. 60.5, 3. Onslaught (4) Md. Ismail 60, 4. Gold Touch (8) Kuldeep Sr. 59.5, 5. Real Thalaviva (6) Mohit 58.5, 6. Super Splash (11) P. Ajeeth K 58.5, 7. Photograph (2) G. Nareesh 55.5, 8. Aquatone (10) A.A. Vikrant 55, 9. Dhanadeepa (3) B. Nikhil 54.5, 10. Marissa (7) Surya Prakash 515, 11. Quality Warrior (5) Santosh 51.5 and 12. The Divinely (12) Rafique Sk. 51.

5. K. MAHIPATHI RAO MEMORIAL GOLCONDA JUVENILE MILLION (1,400m), (Terms) 3-y-o only, 4-00: 1. Advait (8) Shivam 56, 2. Buddy (7) D.S. Deora 56, 3. Bulletproof (9) Trevor 56, 4. Cosmic Gift (2) Kuldeep Sr. 56, 5. Divine Tiger (4) P. Ajeeth K 56, 6. Eminent Gold (1) P. Sai K 56, 7. Garfinkle (10) Ashad Asbar 56, 8. My Way My Rules (3) Afroz K 56, 9. Yali (5) Gaurav 56 and 10. Quattro (6) B.R. Kumar 54.5.

1. BULLETPROOF, 2. DIVINE TIGER, 3. BUDDY.

6. GRAND PARADE PLATE (1,600m), 5-y-o and upward, rated 20 to 45 (Cat. III), 4-40: 1. Miss Marvellous (7) G. Nareesh 60, 2. Mountain Touch (4) Trevor 60, 3. Sargent (6) I. Chisty 58, 4. Take A Breath (11) Rafique Sk. 58, 5. Silver Arrow (3) A.A. Vikrant 57.5, 6. N R I Star (9) Afroz K 54.5, 7. Natu Natu (10) Gaurav 54.5, 8. Sadiya (8) P. Ajeeth K 54, 9. Shubhrah (1) Kuldeep Jr. 53.5, 10. Exclusive Luck (5) B. Nikhil 52.5 and 11. Bold Indian (2) P. Sai K 51.5.

1. MOUNTAIN TOUCH, 2. EXCLUSIVE LUCK, 3. SILVER ARROW. Day's Best: **PRISTINE GLORY.** Jackpot: 2, 3, 4, 5 & 6. Mini Jackpot: 3, 4, 5 & 6. Treble: (i) 1, 2 & 3, (ii) 4, 5 & 6. Tanala: All races.

LIVE TELECAST

Sri Lanka vs. India: First Test, Day 2, Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 9.45 a.m.

Hockey World Cup: Women, Star Sports Select 2, Star Sports 1 & JioHotstar, 1.30 p.m.; China vs India, 4.30 p.m.; 9 p.m. & 12 a.m. (Monday); Men, 3, 6, 7.30 & 10.30 p.m.

Durand Cup: Sony Sports Ten 5 & LIV, 4 & 7 p.m.

LaLiga: FanCode, 8.30 & 10.30 p.m.

Australia fast bowler Josh Hazlewood claimed his 300th wicket in Test cricket during the first innings against Bangladesh in Darwin on Saturday. The 35-year-old reached the milestone when he had Mehidy Hasan Miraz caught behind by Alex Carey.

Cricket: TNCA league, III-B, Triplicane SC vs TSR MSC (PBEL City); S. Railway vs Hunters XI (Wahe Guru-A); Nungambakkam CC vs AG's Office (Tagore); Egmore Club vs Singam Puli CC (Magna-B); Madras Aryan vs UFCC (T. Nagar) (CSK Gurunanak); Prem vs ICF (Venkateswara), 9 a.m.

IV-B, Kovai Knights vs Comrades (St. Bede's-A); Kumbhat vs BRC (Jones Krish); Sir Theagaraya vs TI Cycles (Murugappa); PUC vs CUC (Omega IS); Triplicane CC vs YMA (Union); Social vs Jubilee (MIT).

V-B, Grand Prix vs Chennai P&T (Gandhi Nagar); CCL vs Free Lancers (Engg.); Lusuraj vs Twentieth Century (Gojan); TAN-GECCO vs Companions (St. Patrick's); Indian Oil vs Vepery (Wahe Guru-B); MRC-B vs YMCC (St. Bede's-B), 9.30 a.m.

Motorsports: MRF Challenge two-wheeler racing, MIC, 9 a.m.

A female surfer is shown in the middle of a wave. She is wearing a red and black wetsuit and is holding her white surfboard with both hands. The wave is breaking over her, creating a large splash of white water. The background shows the ocean and a clear sky.

A photograph showing two men seated at a wooden table, engaged in a chess game. The man on the left, wearing a dark jacket, is leaning forward and looking towards the camera. The man on the right, wearing a dark jacket and glasses, is looking towards the chessboard. A black camera on a stand is positioned in front of the chessboard, which is set up on the table. The background is a plain wall with some framed pictures.

The scores: Australia 198 in 53 overs & 161/4 in 53 overs (Steve Smith 44, Cameron Green 43 batting) vs. Bangladesh 426 in 138 overs (Tanzid Hasan 101, Mominul Haque 49, Najmul Shanto 84, Mehidy Hasan Miraz 65, Josh Hazlewood 6/89).

A photograph showing two men seated at a wooden table, engaged in a chess game. The man on the left, wearing a dark jacket, is leaning forward and looking towards the camera. The man on the right, wearing a dark jacket and glasses, is looking towards the chessboard. A black camera on a stand is positioned in front of the chessboard, which is set up on the table. The background is a plain wall with some framed pictures.

Cairns Cup: Anna Muzychuk (Ukr) 2.5 drew with Carissa Yip (USA) 2.5; R. Vaishali 1.5 drew with K. Humpy 2; Alice Lee (USA) 3 drew with Tan Zhongyi (Chn) 4; Alexandra Kosteniuk (Sui) 0.5 drew with Stavroula Tsolakidou (Gre) 3; Divya Deshmukh 3 drew with Bibisara Assaubayeva (Kaz) 3.



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Nature's palette: Sappan heartwood, a natural source of pigment, used to make paint.



Getting it right: Sappan heartwood is boiled in water to extract its natural pigment, which is later used to prepare paint for the idols.



The colour shelf: A palette of natural dye sources and products decorated with biodegradable paints at PJTSAU's Natural Dye Processing and Incubation Centre, Hyderabad.



Hands at work: An artisan applies an orange-yellow coat of paint to a clay Ganesha idol at the PJTSAU centre.

Keep calm and colour on

The Natural Dye Processing and Incubation Centre is developing biodegradable paints and colours from natural dyes as safer alternatives to synthetic dyes



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Natural dyes are gaining renewed attention following the worldwide ban on the use of synthetic dyes. The natural dye industry had nearly vanished by the middle of the 19th century and since then has remained only in a few pockets across select States in the country. The use of synthetic dyes is associated with high environmental pollution and health risks for those handling harmful substances. As awareness of these risks grows, consumers are increasingly shifting towards natural products.

The demand for research in the natural dye industry led to the setting up of the country's premier research institute on dyes – the Natural Dye Processing and Incubation Centre (NDPIC), under the Professor Jayashankar Telangana Agricultural University (PJTSAU) – to come up in Hyderabad.

In 2016, the Telangana State Pollution Control Board (TSPCB) sponsored a project titled “Biodegradable ecopaint production for idol painting with natural dyes on large scale” with an outlay of ₹1 crore. The project enabled PJTSAU to establish a large-scale natural-dye paint production unit, the first of its kind in India, with a production capacity of two tonnes of paint a day.

The same premises also house the production of another promising technology developed by

PJTSAU – ‘Eco-Holi’ powders. The technologies for Eco Paints for Clay Ganesha idols and Eco-Holi powders were developed by the College of Home Science, Hyderabad.

An incubation unit here also helps weavers, artisans and entrepreneurs by providing training and access to its facilities for production and pilot-scale development of new products.

Festival fun

The ‘ecopaint’ production seeks to provide a safer alternative to synthetic colours used to paint Ganesha idols during festivals.

When the idols are immersed in water bodies at the end of the festivities, the biodegradable paint does not have a negative impact as the synthetic dyes, which may contain toxic substances, including heavy metals such as mercury, cadmium and lead. These heavy metals have a devastating impact on human health when they enter water bodies.

Similarly, the eco-friendly Holi powders are also made keeping health and safety in mind.

The goal, therefore, is to ensure that faith and celebration do not come at the cost of the environment and health. Natural dyes and biodegradable colours offer a way to reduce the environmental impact of idol painting while retaining the vibrancy associated with the festival.



Step by step: Natural dye is extracted from boiled sappan heartwood and used as a colouring agent in paint-making.



Against the rules: An artisan from Bihar works on a large Plaster of Paris (PoP) Maha Ganapati idol at a famous idol-making unit in Dhoolpet, Hyderabad. Despite repeated Telangana High Court directives to use eco-friendly clay, many artisans continue crafting of PoP idols due to high demand.



From lab to craft: An artisan preparing the paint to load the spray gun and paint the idol.



Final strokes: A student and a staff member apply the finishing touches on a clay Ganesha idol.



Ready in colour: An artisan prepares natural-dye paint.



Brushwork begins: An artisan hard at work on the Ganesha idols.



Ready to go: Finished clay Ganesha idols await packing to be despatched for sale.